

Chapter 6

Offensive Actions

The Korean People's Army Ground Forces (KPAGF) visualize offensive actions as the decisive form of operations and an ultimate means of imposing their will on the enemy. The KPAGF have six purposes for conducting offensive action and use seven different forms of maneuver in their attacks. They use specific combat formations at the company and platoon level, with tight control by junior leaders. At the regimental and division level, they conduct integrated, dispersed, and limited-objective attacks. At battalion and below, KPAGF units conduct assaults, ambushes, raids, and reconnaissance attacks.

PURPOSE OF THE OFFENSE

6-1. The Korean People's Army (KPA) will likely attack and execute defenses by utilizing each and every gap between enemy forces—no matter how small. The KPA will likely endeavor to fix its enemies' maneuver forces and then flank and turn them with light infantry on the high ground. The goal will be to isolate enemy ground forces—particularly heavy forces—and, while they may not be destroyed, they will be cut off from sustainment support. Surrounded, low on ammunition, and out of fuel is a very psychologically destructive position to be in, and is the reason why entire U.S. units were lost during the Korean War. The primary distinction between different types of offensive actions is the purpose, which depends on three things: the situation, the resources available, and the overarching mission. Purpose is defined by the KPAGF commander in a mission statement, and the unit political officer must approve all of the unit commander's orders. The KPAGF recognize six general purposes of tactical offensive actions:

- Gain freedom of movement.
- Restrict freedom of movement.
- Gain control of key terrain, personnel, or equipment.
- Gain information (conduct reconnaissance).
- Dislocate.
- Disrupt.

6-2. KPAGF task organization of a unit for the offense is determined by function, with primary mission areas of disruption, attack, support, and reserve actions. Analysis of a primary action and enabling functions indicate how to most effectively apply available capabilities. Special mission requirements may emerge during this analysis, requiring specialized capabilities and task organization.

ATTACK TO GAIN FREEDOM OF MOVEMENT

6-3. A KPAGF attack to gain freedom of movement creates a situation in location and timing to allow KPAGF units to apply fires and maneuver in support of a mission. Attack examples can include seizing an important mobility corridor to prevent a counterattack into the flank of another moving unit, destroying an enemy air defense unit so a Korean People's Army Air Force aviation unit can use an air avenue of approach, breaching a complex obstacle to allow an exploitation force to pass through lanes, or executing security tasks to fix a designated enemy in order to create an assailable enemy flank.

ATTACK TO RESTRICT FREEDOM OF MOVEMENT

6-4. A KPAGF attack to restrict freedom of movement degrades enemy ability to maneuver. Attacks can include denying key terrain, ambushing moving units, dominating airspace, or fixing an enemy formation.

Tactical tasks often associated with restricting freedom of movement are ambush, block, canalize, contain, fix, and isolate.

ATTACK TO GAIN CONTROL OF KEY TERRAIN, PERSONNEL, OR EQUIPMENT

6-5. A KPAGF attack to gain control of key terrain, personnel, or equipment prevents use of a designated capability by an enemy. Tactical tasks associated with this type of attack include raid, clear, destroy, occupy, retain, secure, and seize. Other means to gain control can be psychological warfare, information attack, computer warfare, electronic warfare, or other elements of electronic intelligence warfare (EIW).

ATTACK TO GAIN INFORMATION (CONDUCT RECONNAISSANCE)

6-6. A KPAGF attack to gain information collects data to create or update situational awareness and understanding in an operational environment (OE). In this case, the purpose is not to locate to destroy, fix, or occupy, but rather to gain information about the enemy. Quite often, the KPAGF will have to penetrate or circumvent the enemy's security units and conduct an attack in order to determine the enemy's location, disposition, capabilities, and intentions.

ATTACK TO DISLOCATE

6-7. A KPAGF attack to dislocate employs units to obtain significant positional advantage, rendering the enemy's dispositions less valuable, perhaps even irrelevant. It aims to make the enemy expose units to a more dangerous situation by forcing it to react to the dislocating action. Dislocation requires enemy commanders to make a choice: accept neutralization of part of their unit or risk its destruction while repositioning. Turning movements and envelopments produce dislocation. Artillery or other direct or indirect fires may cause an enemy to either move to a more tenable location or risk severe attrition. Typical tactical tasks associated with dislocation are ambush, interdict, and neutralize.

ATTACK TO DISRUPT

6-8. A KPAGF attack to disrupt interferes with the synchronization of enemy actions, plans, or tempo. Attacks to disrupt often have a strong EIW component to disrupt, limit, deny, or degrade the enemy's use of the electromagnetic spectrum, especially its command and control (C2) and communications systems. The KPA does not limit its attacks to military targets or enemy combatants; an attack to disrupt may be carried out against noncombatant civilians and infrastructure.

PLANNING THE OFFENSE

6-9. Key elements of planning offensive missions are—

- Determine the offensive objective.
- Ensure there is adequate logistical support to accomplish the objective.
- Determine available time to plan and prepare actions.
- Organize units by functional mission task requirements.
- Conduct EIW activities, including psychological warfare, available and authorized at the command planning level.
- Initiate offensive actions.

PLANNED OFFENSE

6-10. A planned offense is an offensive mission or action conducted when there is sufficient time and situational understanding to prepare and rehearse units for specific tasks. Key considerations in offensive planning includes but are not limited to—

- Implement a plan for reconnaissance, intelligence, surveillance, and target acquisition (RISTA).
- Determine the when, where, and how of enemy plans, actions, and intentions.
- Identify enemy vulnerabilities and how to exploit those weaknesses.

- Locate critical nodes of the enemy's combat systems and when to most effectively interdict them.
- Enact functions that reinforce opportunities for offensive actions in the area of operations (AO).
- Determine the offensive method that will deny the enemy its tactical objectives.
- Task-organize units by function to attack and support with enabling functions.
- Create or take advantage of a tactical window of opportunity.
- Plan for offensive actions given success of defensive actions.

SITUATIONAL OFFENSE

6-11. A situational offense is an offensive action or mission conducted when temporary circumstances emerge and require rapid and timely offensive actions and drills to take advantage of a tactical opportunity against an enemy. A window of opportunity could be exploited in conditions such as—

- A key enemy unit, system, or capability is identified and vulnerable.
- An enemy repositioning of units in progress indicates a vulnerability in its formation array.
- An enemy concentration of units creates a lucrative target group.

FORMS OF KPAGF OFFENSIVE MANEUVER

6-12. KPAGF maneuver units use seven different types of offensive maneuvers when they attack an enemy. A unit, such as a division, may employ more than one type of maneuver, with its subordinate units using different forms. These types of maneuver are called—

- Encirclement.
- Penetration.
- Thrust.
- Holding.
- Turning.
- Infiltration.
- Besetment.

Encirclement Maneuver (P'owi)

6-13. The encirclement maneuver, *p'owi* (pronounced “po we”) in Korean, is conducted by the KPAGF at both the operational and tactical levels. While KPAGF corps- and army-level headquarters may use up to two divisions to conduct an operational encirclement, any encirclement done at the division and lower level will normally use the entire unit. The intent of the encirclement maneuver is to intercept the majority of the retreating enemy unit(s), encircle it, and destroy it. During the Korean War, North Korean units consistently attempted a double envelopment of South Korean and U.S. units. The KPAGF commander will often choose a location for the intended encirclement somewhere between the location of the enemy's front-line positions and its reserve unit. The KPAGF anticipate that successful penetration or thrust maneuvers in the area will cause units in adjacent AOs to withdraw or move to alternate positions. The KPA believes enemy units are most vulnerable during a retrograde operation, making them susceptible to encirclement and annihilation. Figure 6-1 on page 6-4 is an example of an encirclement. The KPAGF further break down their encirclement maneuvers based on the situation:

- Partitioned destruction: encirclement of large units.
- Compressed destruction: encirclement of smaller units.
- Fire power destruction: destruction of units in narrow areas and while fighting encirclement operations.
- Raid destruction: destruction of units in built-up areas.

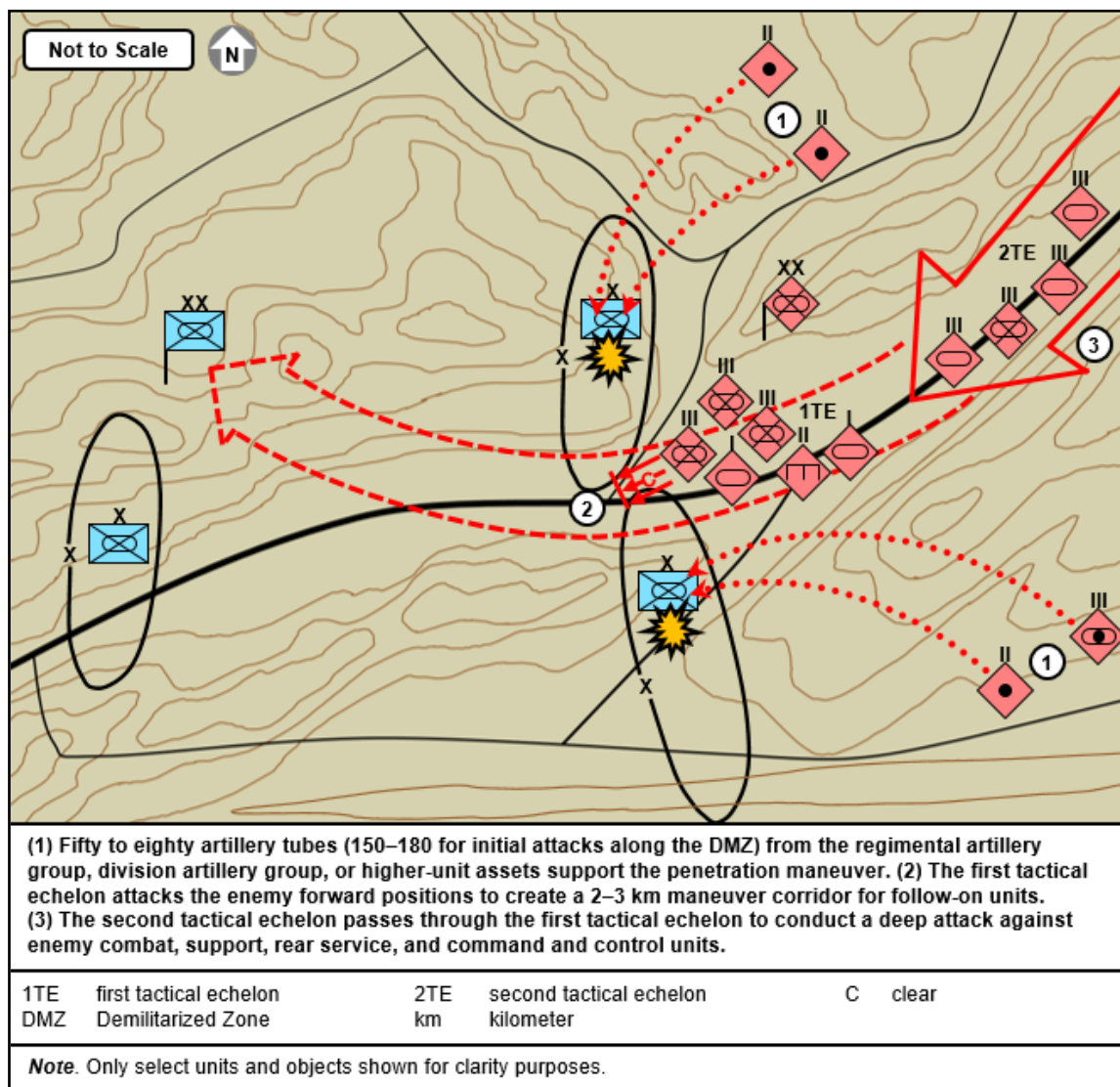


Figure 6-1. Encirclement maneuver (example)

Penetration Maneuver (Tolp'a)

6-14. The penetration maneuver, *tolp'a* (pronounced “dolpa”) in Korean, is normally a division-level operation to destroy a defending unit and create a maneuver corridor 2–3 km in width. The penetration is normally supported by 50 to 80 tubes of mortar, artillery, and rocket fire for each kilometer of the defensive position under attack. Along the demilitarized zone (DMZ), a penetration during an initial attack by the KPAGF would likely receive support from 150 to 180 tubes per kilometer. The purpose of the penetration is for a first tactical echelon unit to create a gap wide enough to allow a second tactical echelon unit to pass through. Once the first tactical echelon unit penetrates the front-line position, it would set up a situational defensive position while the second tactical echelon unit passes through in order to conduct a deep attack against the combat support, rear service, and C2 units in the enemy’s division or corps rear area. See figure 6-2 for an example of a penetration maneuver.

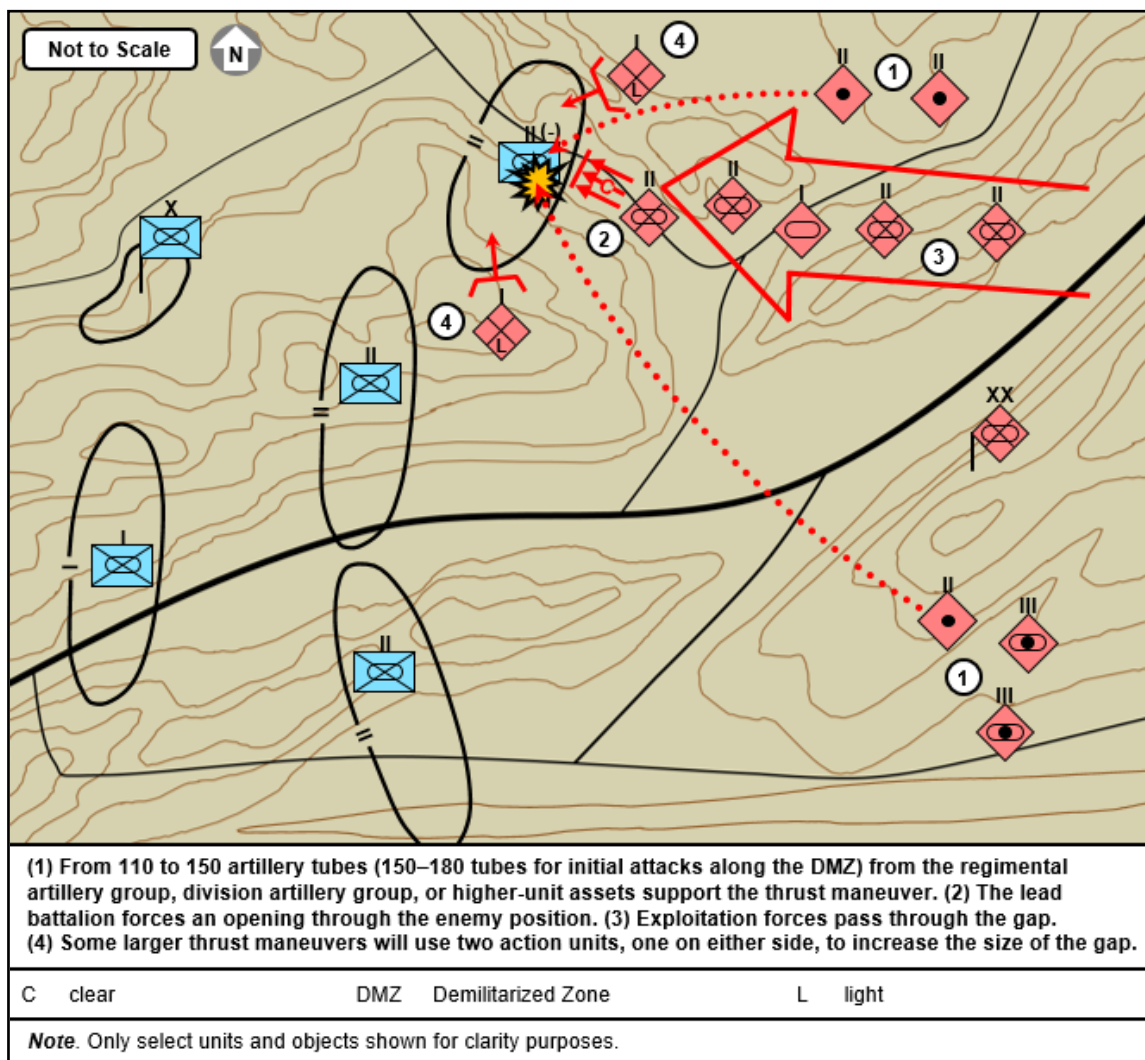


Figure 6-2. Penetration maneuver (example)

Thrust Maneuver (Ch'ōmip)

6-15. The thrust maneuver, *ch'ōmip* (pronounced “chim ip”) in Korean, is conducted by a company, battalion, or regiment against an enemy strongpoint. The normal assault area will only be 600–800 m in width, with a maximum of 1,000 m. The attacking unit will receive support from between 110 and 150 tubes of mortar, artillery, and rockets. Units along the DMZ during an initial attack would likely receive support from 150 to 180 tubes if designated to conduct a thrust maneuver. Similar to a wedge splitting a log, the small attacking unit would force an opening through the strongpoint in order to allow an exploitation force to pass through the gap. For a larger thrust maneuver, the KPAGF may use two action units, one on each side of the gap, to create a larger hole for the following exploitation force. Once the second tactical echelon force passes through the gap, it could receive one of four missions:

- Continue the attack by striking the rear or flank of the targeted enemy unit.
- Attack the rear or flank of a unit adjacent to the targeted unit.
- Open a blocked maneuver corridor.
- Assist in the passage of a larger force conducting a turning maneuver or besetment maneuver in the enemy's division or corps rear area.

See figure 6-3 on page 6-6 for an example of a thrust maneuver.

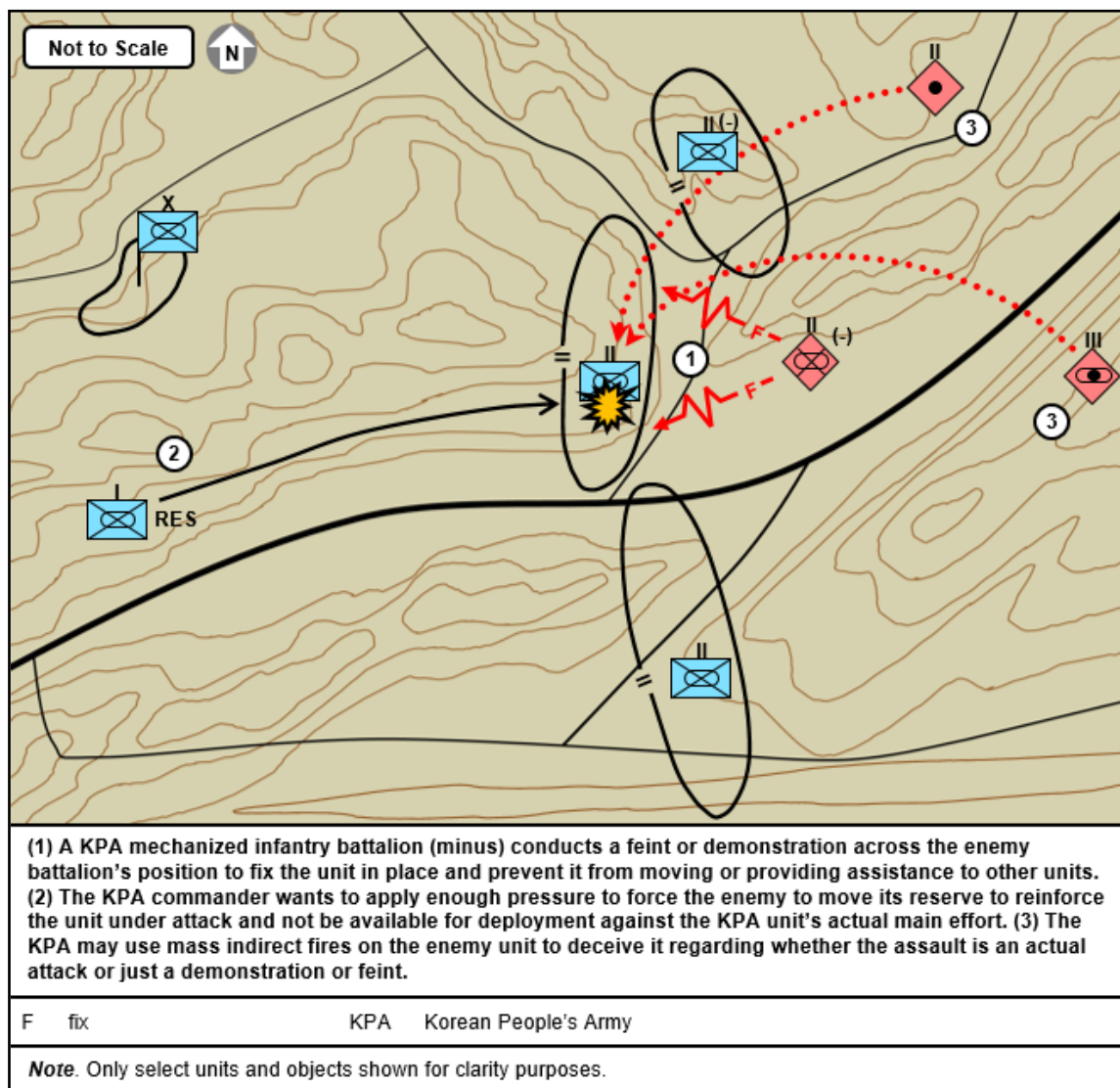


Figure 6-3. Thrust maneuver (example)

Holding Maneuver (Kyönje)

6-16. The holding maneuver, *kyönje* (pronounced “kyun jae”) in Korean, is a type of dispersed attack to fix a larger force with a much smaller KPAGF unit. The KPAGF’s intent is to draw enemy reserves away from the main effort. Holding maneuvers can be conducted by any size unit, from company to division. The holding unit will often serve as part of a feint or demonstration across a larger front. It may employ small-unit raids or mass indirect fires to deceive the enemy on its actual size and cause the committal of enemy reserves to its location. If a second tactical echelon unit is successful in passing through a penetration or thrust in an adjacent AO, the holding unit may conduct an actual attack to prevent the reserves or the unit under the holding attack from going to the aid of a unit being encircled or under besetment. See figure 6-4 for an example of a holding maneuver.

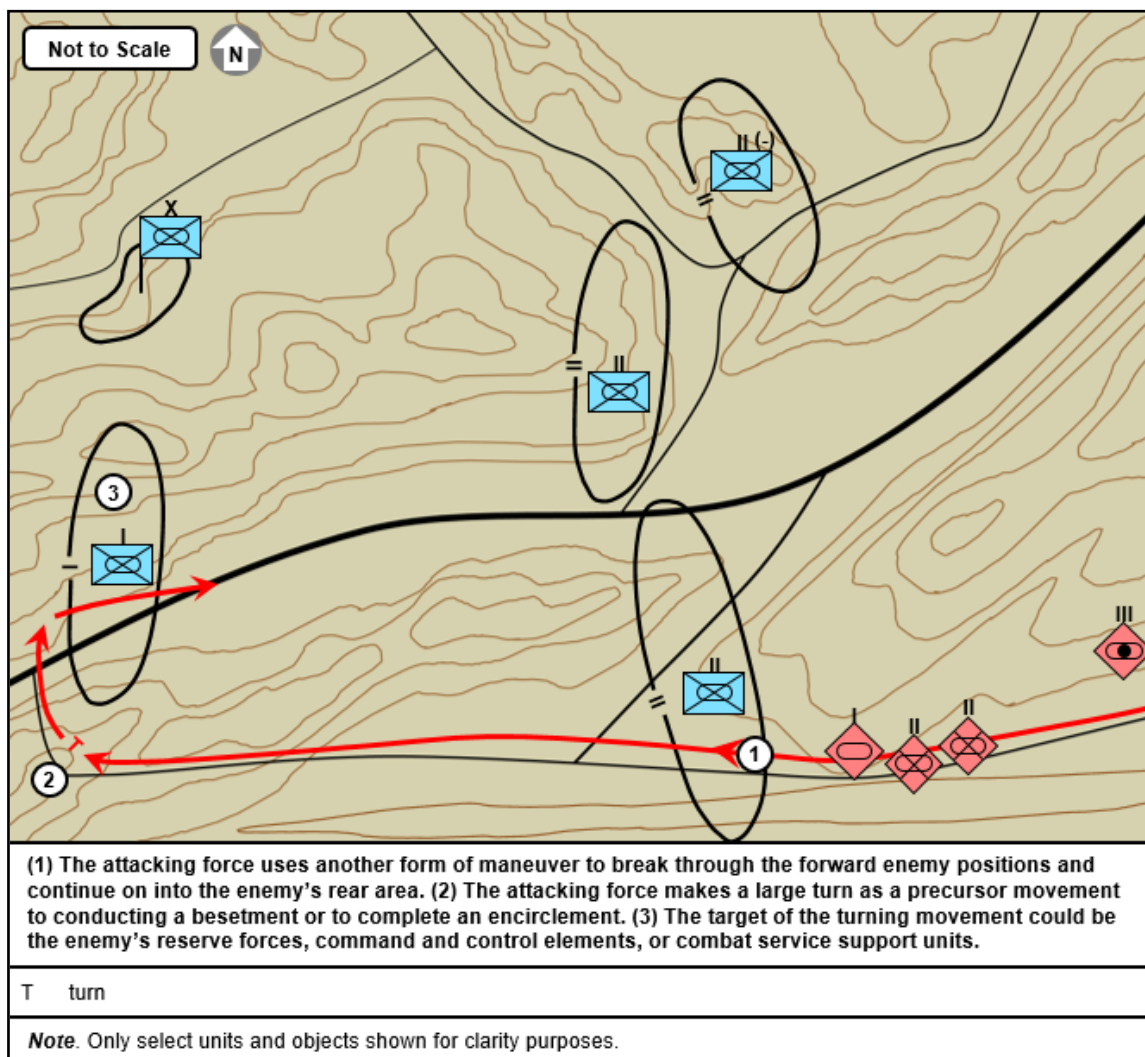


Figure 6-4. Holding maneuver (example)

Turning Maneuver (Uhoe)

6-17. The turning maneuver, *uhoe* (pronounced “wu hoe”) in Korean, is a precursor movement to establishing an encirclement position or conducting a besetment of an enemy defensive position. KPAGF corps- and army-level headquarters conduct operational turning maneuvers, while division and lower headquarters conduct tactical turning movements. This maneuver can be used against the enemy's reserve or to coerce an enemy unit to abandon its primary defensive positions and fight in an undesirable direction. The turning unit may use limited visibility (night or inclement weather) or rough terrain (swamps, rice paddies, rivers, or mountains) to avoid undesirable contact with the enemy. If there is no natural gap in the enemy's defensive position, the turning unit could be part of a second tactical echelon that has passed through a gap in the front lines created by a penetration or thrust by a first tactical echelon unit. See figure 6-5 on page 6-8 for an example of a turning movement.

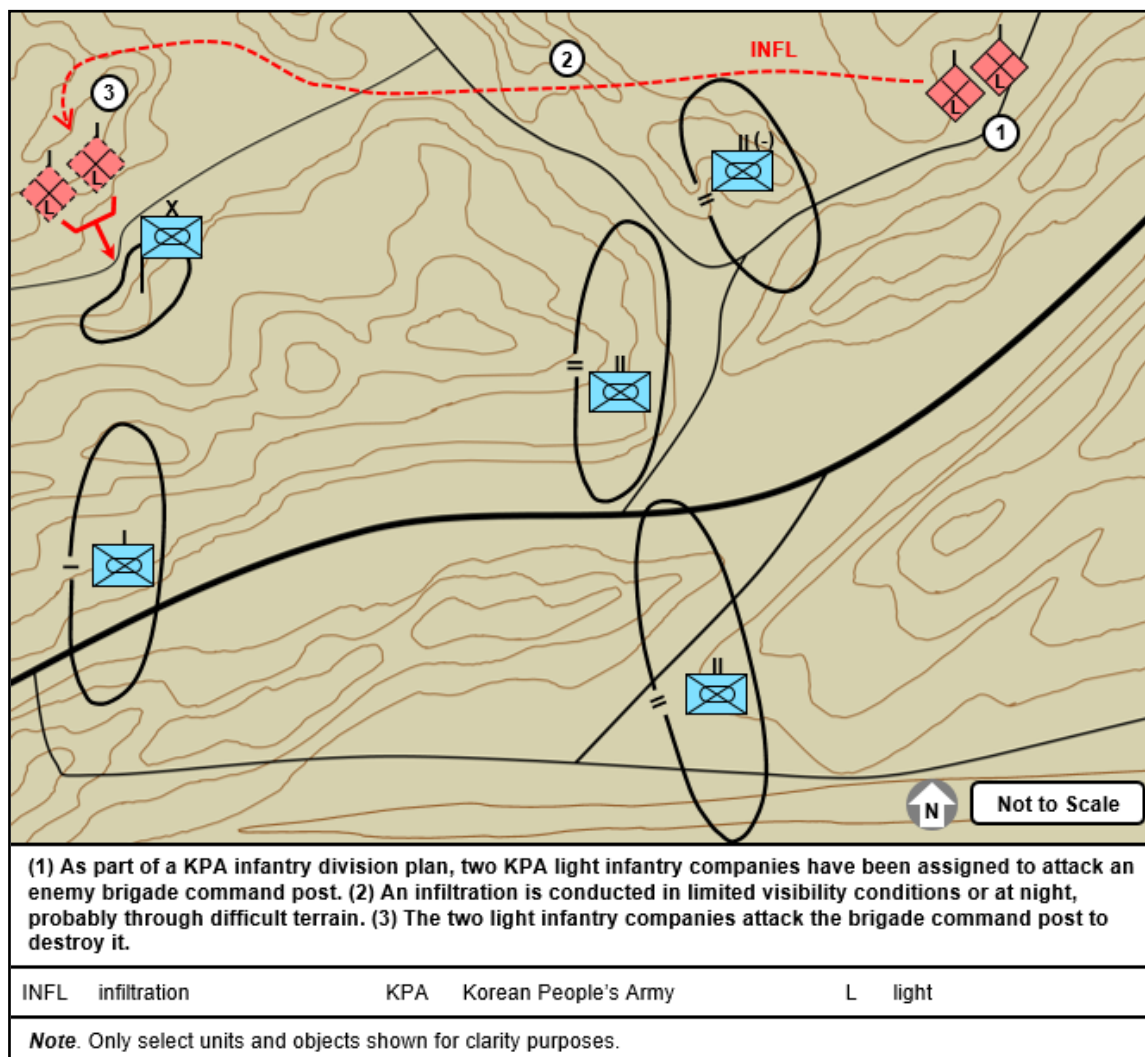


Figure 6-5. Turning maneuver (example)

Infiltration Maneuver (Ch'imt'u)

6-18. The infiltration maneuver, *ch'imt'u* (pronounced "chim tu") in Korean, is an attempt to pass a KPAGF unit through the enemy's lines undetected in order to establish attack positions in the enemy's division or corps rear area. The infiltration unit(s) will use limited visibility or rough terrain to pass through the enemy's front lines undetected. The mountainous terrain on the Korean Peninsula, with most of the mountains running north-south, makes light infantry traversing the ridgelines an excellent method of reaching the enemy's rear area. A KPAGF division will normally designate several light infantry companies as infiltration units. While KPAGF units lower than division do not have designated infiltration units, regular KPAGF infantry may be used in that role. KPAGF infantry regiments will normally employ a single infantry company, and infantry battalions will employ one platoon to conduct infiltration maneuvers within their AOs. KPAGF units larger than division may also use infiltration maneuvers. An infantry corps will likely use the majority of its light infantry brigade and attached sniper brigade (four battalions each) during an offensive operation to attack the enemy division or corps rear areas. These infiltrating units will normally attack enemy C2 elements or artillery positions, block enemy reinforcements, or secure chokepoints to facilitate the movement of friendly follow-on units. See figure 6-6 for an example of an infiltration maneuver.

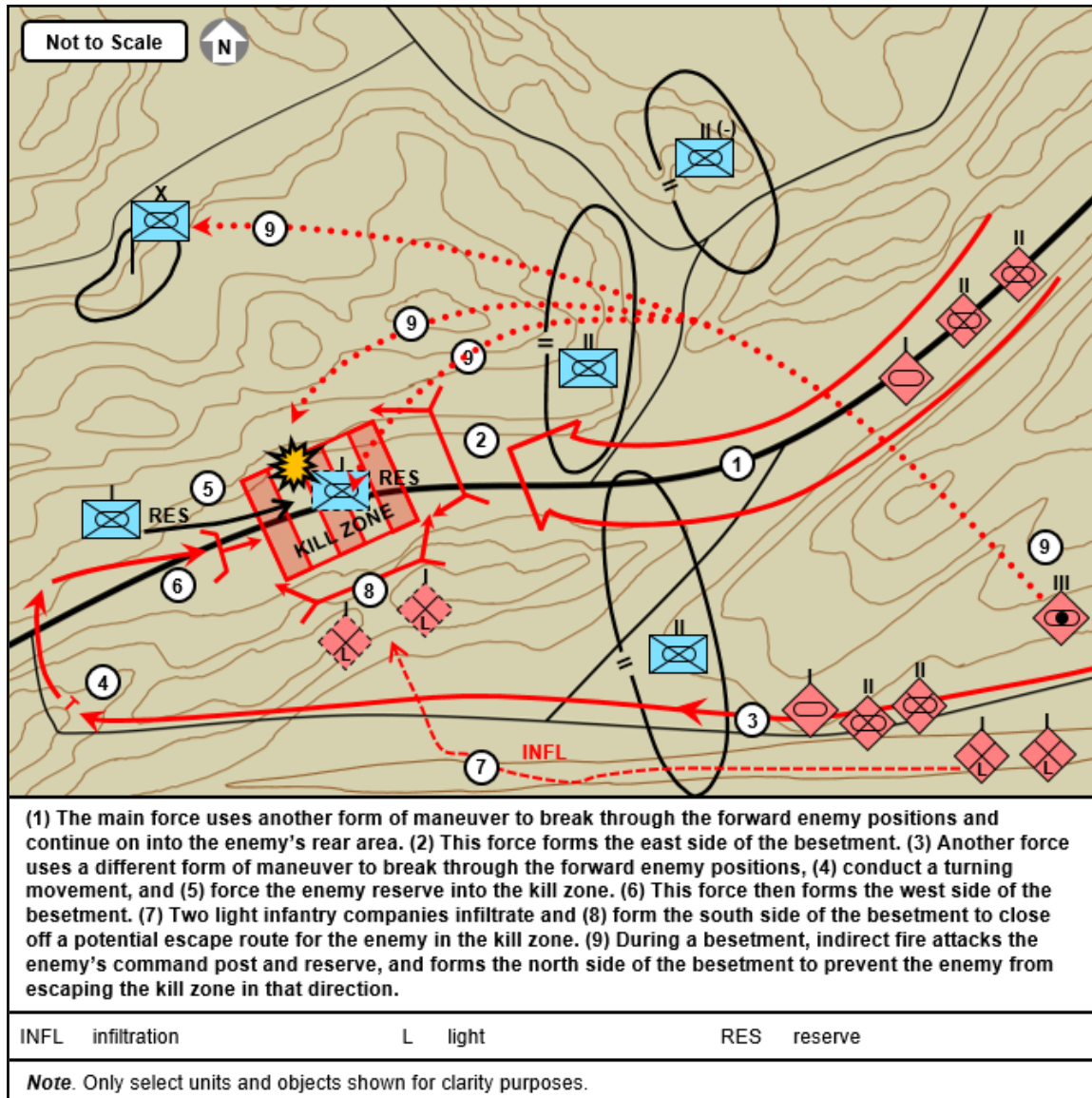


Figure 6-6. Infiltration maneuver (example)

Besetment Maneuver (P'och'o)

6-19. The besetment maneuver, *p'och'o* (pronounced "po cho") in Korean, is conducted by KPAGF units at the regimental and lower level to destroy units in defensive strongpoints. For success, the KPAGF unit making the attack desires a 3:1 ratio of friendly to enemy units, so regiments attack battalion strongpoints, battalions attack company strongpoints; and companies attack platoon strongpoints. The intent is to attack the defending unit on multiple flanks to make it impossible for the enemy unit to escape. There are four types of KPAGF besetments, but any flank not under direct fire will be covered with indirect fire. The four types of besetments are—

- Front and one flank.
- Front and two flanks.
- Front and rear.
- Front, rear, and two flanks.

See figure 6-7 on page 6-10 for an example of a besetment maneuver.

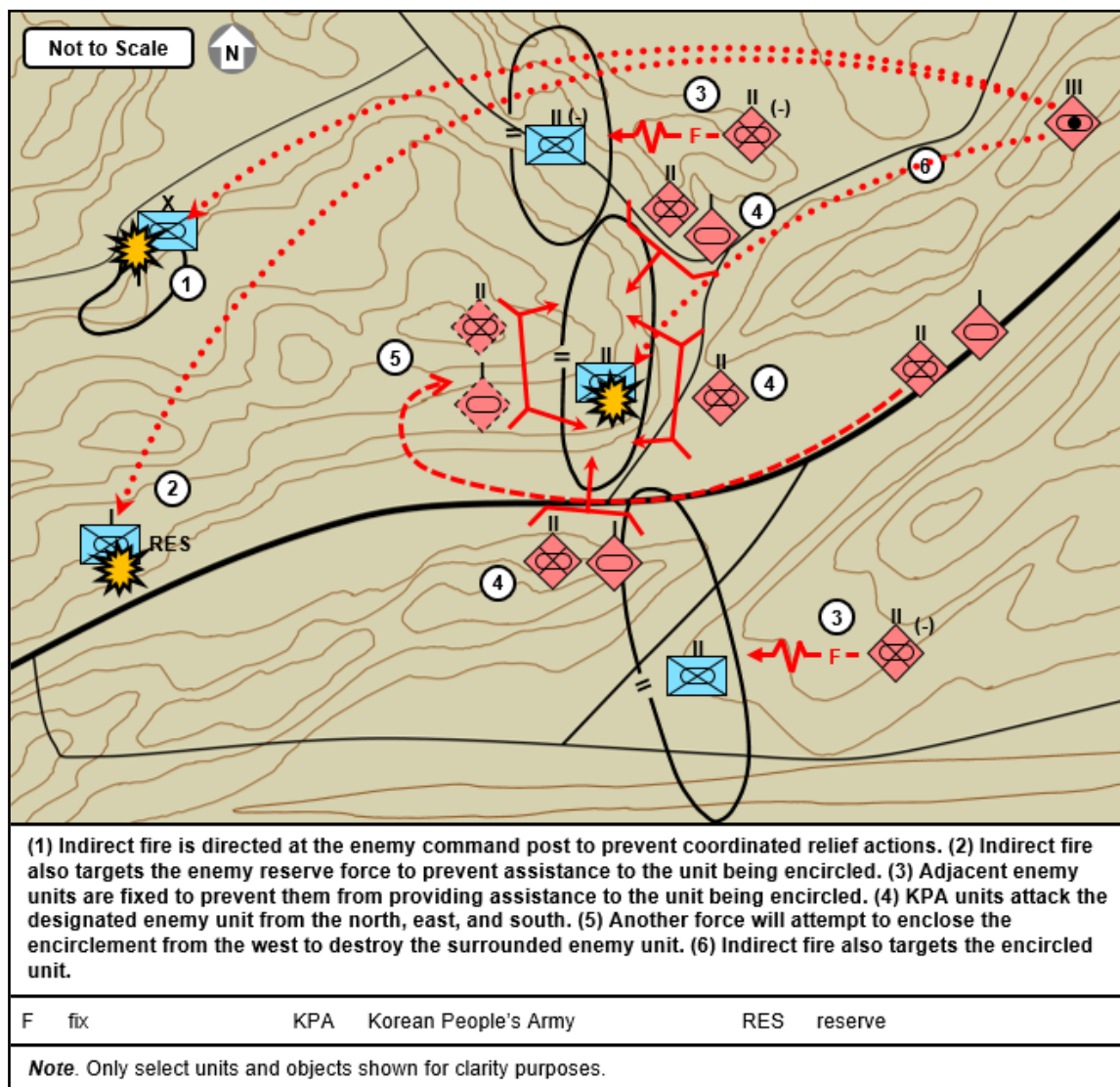


Figure 6-7. Besetment maneuver (example)

FUNCTIONAL ORGANIZATION OF FORCES—DIVISIONS, BRIGADES, AND REGIMENTS

6-20. A KPAGF divisional, brigade, or regimental commander specifies the initial required functions of a force within the command and task-organizes resources to achieve integrated functions in a mission. Given the resources available at this level, multiple functional mission tasks can be assigned to a division or lower-level unit. The KPAGF commander can adjust task organization of forces during an operation to address emergent tactical conditions.

FUNCTIONAL ORGANIZATION OF ELEMENTS—DETACHMENTS, BATTALIONS, AND SUBORDINATE UNITS

6-21. Detachments, battalions, and companies are assigned mission tasks based on a function to achieve, but differ in how task organization occurs compared to a tactical regiment, brigade, or division. The KPAGF task-organizes battalions and companies as detachments to accomplish a single tactical task; a detachment is assigned multiple functional mission tasks only when necessary.

Note. A KPAGF commander gives a detachment a functional designation based on the role it has in the overall mission or the specific function it will perform. For example, a detachment assigned to conduct a raid may be called a raiding detachment.

PREPARING FOR THE OFFENSE

6-22. In the preparation phase, the KPAGF organize an AO, zone of reconnaissance responsibility, and functional units to optimize successful offensive actions and create or seize opportunities for actions. Offensive preparations apply a systems warfare approach to degrade the enemy's system of systems, deny integrated performance of the enemy combat system, and create vulnerabilities that KPAGF units can exploit.

MAINTAIN CONTACT

6-23. KPAGF offensive actions maintain contact with enemy units for relevant situational awareness and understanding of an OE and probable or known enemy actions. Reconnaissance and counterreconnaissance actions include rapid reorganization or reconstitution of assets to ensure no gaps in situational awareness and understanding of the enemy, AO, or zone of reconnaissance responsibility. Effective RISTA guide prudent use of KPAGF combat power to achieve the KPA offensive mission.

CONDUCT MOBILITY PREPARATIONS

6-24. The KPAGF position logistics support in anticipation of offensive mission task and enemy actions. Preparations consider mobile logistics support, caches, and other sustainment requirements as lines of communications extend with the directions of offensive actions. KPA doctrine places the burden on each level of command to ensure the proper logistics are in place to complete its mission.

PREPARE FOR CONTINGENCIES

6-25. The KPAGF prepare for a primary concept of mission execution, as well as considering branches and sequels to primary plans. Plans include the possibility of other contingencies and are developed with flexible abilities in terms of priorities of effort and support. The KPA commander normally designates units as reserves or rapid response units to handle unforeseen contingencies.

REHEARSE KEY MISSION TASKS

6-26. The KPAGF commander establishes the priorities for critical action rehearsals, effort, and support. The unit rehearses those actions as realistically as possible in the time allocated for preparation. Typical actions rehearsed in preparation for an KPAGF offensive mission include but are not limited to—

- RISTA updates.
- Counterreconnaissance.
- EIW, including psychological warfare.
- Integrated fires support.
- Battle handover from security and disruption units to main- and supporting-effort attack units.
- Main- and supporting-effort attacks.
- Mission, counterattack, and exploitation options.

EXECUTING THE OFFENSE

6-27. Successful execution of a KPAGF offensive mission is often followed by continued offensive action to exploit tactical opportunities. In some situations, the offense may temporarily transition to the defense in order to consolidate gains, defeat enemy counterattacks, or avoid culmination. The intent is to continue the KPAGF's offensive actions. The KPA commander does not only want to secure the objectives, but also to annihilate or destroy the enemy units at the same time.

NATURE OF THE OFFENSE

6-28. When planning an offensive attack at the division or lower-unit level, the KPAGF base their tactics and techniques on the current posture of the enemy. Based on enemy activity, strength, and the KPAGF's unit strength, the KPAGF commander will choose the form(s) of maneuver to use when making the attack. The KPAGF's posture can be one of the following—

- An attack against a defending enemy. The enemy is in a defensive position and not on the move.
- An attack against an attacking enemy. The KPAGF meet the enemy when it is on the move to conduct an offensive.
- An attack against a retreating enemy. The enemy is in retreat and the KPAGF want to flank the units conducting the retrograde movement in order to rout them.

6-29. At all levels of command, the KPAGF emphasize the isolation of the objective by infiltrating units behind and to the flanks of the enemy to prevent reinforcement.

MAINTAIN CONTACT

6-30. The KPAGF ensure their units maintain contact with key elements of enemy units throughout the mission. Actions include rapid reconstitution of reconnaissance capabilities for a continuum of timely and accurate information and intelligence. The KPAGF also wants to maintain close contact with the enemy to help mitigate the latter's superior aerial weapons systems and indirect fire capabilities. Due to the enemy's aversion to friendly fire casualties, it may choose to not fire at KPAGF units in close proximity to its own forces for fear of killing its own soldiers.

EXECUTE MISSION TASKS AND DRILLS

6-31. The KPAGF conduct mission tasks and drills with aggressive and flexible actions that have been practiced to standards. As situational conditions evolve during a mission, clear and concise modifications to methodical and practiced combined arms actions allow the KPAGF to rapidly adapt and react to new tactical conditions.

COMPANY COMBAT FORMATIONS

6-32. There are three primary movement formations used by a KPAGF infantry company when there is the possibility of contact with the enemy: wedge, V, and line. The chosen formation is based on the terrain, the front the company must cover, and the expectation level of enemy contact. Figure 6-8 illustrates these formations.

Wedge Formation

6-33. The wedge formation consists of three infantry platoons—one forward and two trailing—with 150–200 m between any two platoons. The company headquarters locates itself in the center of the formation, with additional assets such as extra machine guns behind but near the company commander. This formation provides the most all-around security for the company as it moves forward. It allows the company commander to make contact with a small element, but maintain two maneuver elements to develop the situation.

V Formation

6-34. The V formation is the reverse of the wedge formation, and is used when the KPAGF infantry company needs to cover a wider axis of advance. Depending upon terrain, the two lead infantry platoons are 300–350 m apart, with the trail platoon 150–200 m to the rear in the center. The company headquarters is in the center of the formation, with the attached weapons behind it but in front of the trail platoon. If contact with the enemy is made, the company commander can use the trail platoon and any attached heavy weapons to maneuver while the lead infantry platoon that made contact fixes the enemy.

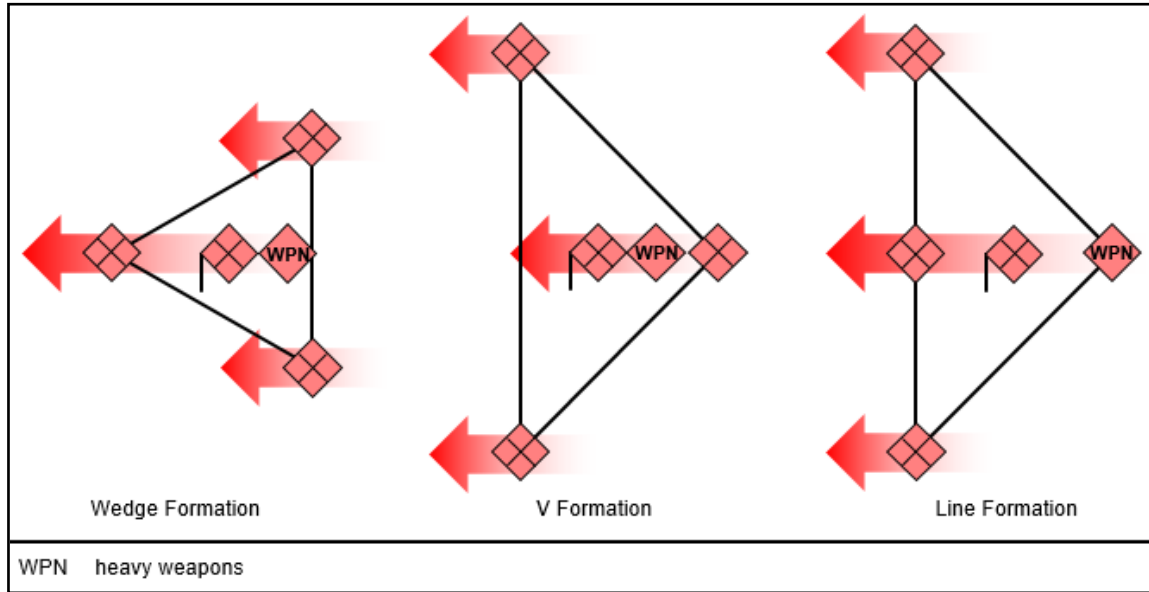


Figure 6-8. KPAGF primary small-unit (company and below) movement formations

Line Formation

6-35. The company line formation places all three KPAGF infantry platoons parallel to each other with approximately 150–200 m between platoons. The infantry platoons may be in any formation dependent upon the terrain, the likelihood of enemy contact, and the need for rapid movement. Any heavy weapons or reserve trail 150–200 m behind the infantry platoons. The KPAGF infantry company headquarters is located about halfway between the infantry platoons and the heavy weapons or company reserve.

PLATOON COMBAT FORMATIONS

6-36. At the infantry platoon level, the KPAGF may use the column or double column for faster movement. If enemy contact is possible, a KPAGF infantry platoon uses the same three formations as the company: wedge, V, and line. The primary difference is the distance between subordinate units.

Wedge Formation

6-37. In the wedge formation, one KPAGF infantry squad is forward with the two trailing squads 75–100 m to the rear of the lead squad, depending upon the terrain. There is about 50 m between the two trailing squads. The platoon headquarters is in the center between the two trailing squads. This formation allows the platoon leader to make contact with the smallest element—the squad—while allowing for the remaining two-thirds of the unit to maneuver if the leading squad makes contact with the enemy.

V Formation

6-38. The V formation is the reverse of the wedge formation and is used if the KPAGF infantry platoon is required to cover a wider area in its movement. Depending upon the terrain, all squads will maintain approximately 100 m distant from each other. The headquarters is in the center of the formation, about halfway between the leading and trailing squads. If contact is made with the enemy, the trailing squad can maneuver to support the squad in contact, and depending on the situation, the other leading squad could also maneuver to support the one in contact.

Line Formation

6-39. The KPAGF infantry platoon line formation places all three KPAGF infantry squads parallel to each other with approximately 50 m between them. The platoon headquarters is usually in a trailing position behind the center squad. This formation is most often used when enemy contact is imminent. The KPAGF soldiers do not go “on line” until they are approximately 150 m from the objective.

KPAGF INFANTRY PLATOON ASSAULT TECHNIQUES

6-40. While terrain will dictate the actual distances, a KPAGF infantry platoon will likely complete the following actions in an attack—

- Platoon moves in a wedge, V, or line formation until reaching around 900 m (actual distance based on terrain) from the known enemy position.
- KPAGF platoon leader designates three assault lines, with the third line 100 m from the enemy position found through previous reconnaissance.
- Platoon deploys in a “skirmish” line about 150 m in width.
- On the platoon leader’s signal, pairs of KPAGF soldiers “leapfrog” toward the first assault line without firing their weapons.
- Attached heavy machine guns set up around the first assault line, aimed at the enemy positions.
- When the platoon reaches the first assault line, the heavy machine guns open fire on the objective.
- Soldiers use fire and movement to assail the enemy position.
- At 30 m, soldiers throw grenades.

6-41. KPAGF soldiers are trained to fire only one-third of their allocated ammunition between the first and second assault lines, and another one-third between the second and third assault lines. The remainder of the allocated ammunition is used in the final assault from 100 m away (the third assault line) to arrival at the objective.

6-42. After the attack is launched there is no turning back, as any change of plans must be approved by the political officer. Once the platoon attacks, it will continue until the objective is taken or the last man falls. Any KPAGF soldier in the platoon that fails to continue the assault or tries to retreat will be shot by the political officer. Of note, the regiment is the lowest level within the KPAGF unit structure where the commander can order a withdrawal.

SEIZE TACTICAL OPPORTUNITIES

6-43. While KPA doctrine emphasizes decentralized execution of a mission task and use of tactical initiative, actual execution of the initiative may not occur because of fear of any repercussions due to the failure of the mission. KPA units at the lower echelons of command may do nothing without orders from above. It remains to be seen whether subordinate units will take advantage of emergent opportunities and adapt tactical actions in concert with the purpose of a mission order and its intent. If a KPA commander takes initiative and acts without orders from above and succeeds, the commander will likely be rewarded. If the commander takes personal initiative and fails, the punishment will be severe. There appears to be no middle ground for KPA commanders.

TYPES OF OFFENSIVE ACTION—DIVISIONS AND REGIMENTS

6-44. The types of KPAGF offensive action are tactical methods and also guide adaptive decision making in how to best achieve a mission. An offensive mission typically includes subordinate units executing specified offensive and defensive functional actions within an overall offensive mission framework.

6-45. The two primary types of offensive missions at tactical regimental to divisional operations are integrated attacks and dispersed attacks. The KPAGF also conducts some limited objective attack variants. A KPAGF tactical commander may use both of the primary forms of offense simultaneously throughout an AO. A KPAGF offensive action or series of engagements may include subordinate units executing various combinations of mobile and area defenses, as well as offensive actions, within an overall offensive mission framework.

ATTACK

6-46. An attack is an offensive operation emphasizing the destruction of enemy units, seizure and securing terrain, or both. It seeks to achieve tactical decision through primarily military means by defeating the enemy's military power. This defeat does not necessarily result from the destruction of systems but through the disruption, dislocation, and subsequent paralysis that occurs when combat units are rendered irrelevant by the loss of the capability or will to continue the fight.

6-47. There are two types of attack: integrated attack and dispersed attack. The KPAGF do not have a separate design for exploitation or pursuit as distinct offensive missions, but they are considered a subsequent norm to integrated and dispersed attacks. Situational conditions and timely risk assessment indicate when these actions are prudent to conduct following a successful attack. Both types of attack can use any of the seven forms of offensive movement.

Integrated Attack

6-48. The primary objective of an integrated attack is destroying the enemy's will and ability to fight. The KPA recognizes modern militaries cannot continue without adequate logistics support or effective C2 and communications, and emphasizes an attack on these targets.

6-49. Integrated attacks are characterized by actions to—

- Target and focus attacks on enemy logistics, C2, and communications.
- Degrade enemy situational understanding with EIW elements, especially psychological warfare.
- Disrupt enemy forces with reinforced complex terrain and disruption forces.
- Fix designated enemy forces.
- Isolate targeted critical components of the enemy combat system.
- Attack targeted critical components of the enemy combat system.
- Defeat enemy forces with fires and maneuver, supported by EIW.
- Destroy enemy will and resolve to continue armed conflict.

6-50. The KPAGF prefers to conduct integrated attacks when most or all of the following conditions exist—

- Possess superior combat power over enemy forces.
- Maintain the ability to disrupt or destroy enemy aviation or missile assets in AO airspace.
- Degrade enemy standoff reconnaissance and attack systems to an acceptable levels of risk assessment as determined by the KPA commander.

6-51. Integrated attack is an offensive action where the KPAGF seeks a military decision by destroying the enemy's will or ability to continue armed conflict through the application of combined arms effects. An integrated attack is often conducted when the KPAGF enjoys overmatch of its enemy and is able to focus significant aspects of combat power on an objective. Integrated attack can also be directed against a more sophisticated and capable opponent when a tactical opportunity emerges or is created during an operation. Figure 6-9 on page 6-16 is an example of a KPAGF mechanized division conducting an integrated attack. The numbers shown in the text below match the numbers in figure 6-9.

6-52. Though a KPAGF division can conduct an encirclement at operational level, many of its subordinate units may be involved in other forms of military movement. While the main assault forces conduct the attack in the form of an encirclement, fixing forces may conduct thrust, penetration, or holding movements in their own AO. In figure 6-9 on page 6-16, one of the assault forces also conducts a turning movement before becoming part of the encirclement force.

6-53. For an attack, KPAGF doctrine only requires a 2:1 advantage at the point of the attack. It designates the main attack advance on a much narrower attack zone than the secondary attacks, which requires the rest of the division to disperse more widely throughout the remainder of the divisional front. The KPAGF commander's intent is to provide the appearance to enemy units that there is significant military force to their front, to keep them from assisting other units.

6-54. The KPAGF division's artillery assets are located in the division artillery group. The division artillery group may receive additional indirect fire assets from the corps, dependent upon whether the division is

conducting the main or a supporting attack. The division artillery group initiates the attack (#1) by firing indirect artillery and rockets not only at the frontline enemy units, but at the enemy brigade command post (CP) and reserve as well. (For clarity purposes, only three artillery strikes are shown.) The division artillery group's task is to provide adequate indirect fire in order to achieve neutralization of the brigade reserve; disrupt the C2 of the brigade CP; and harass at a minimum or neutralize, if possible, the frontline units.

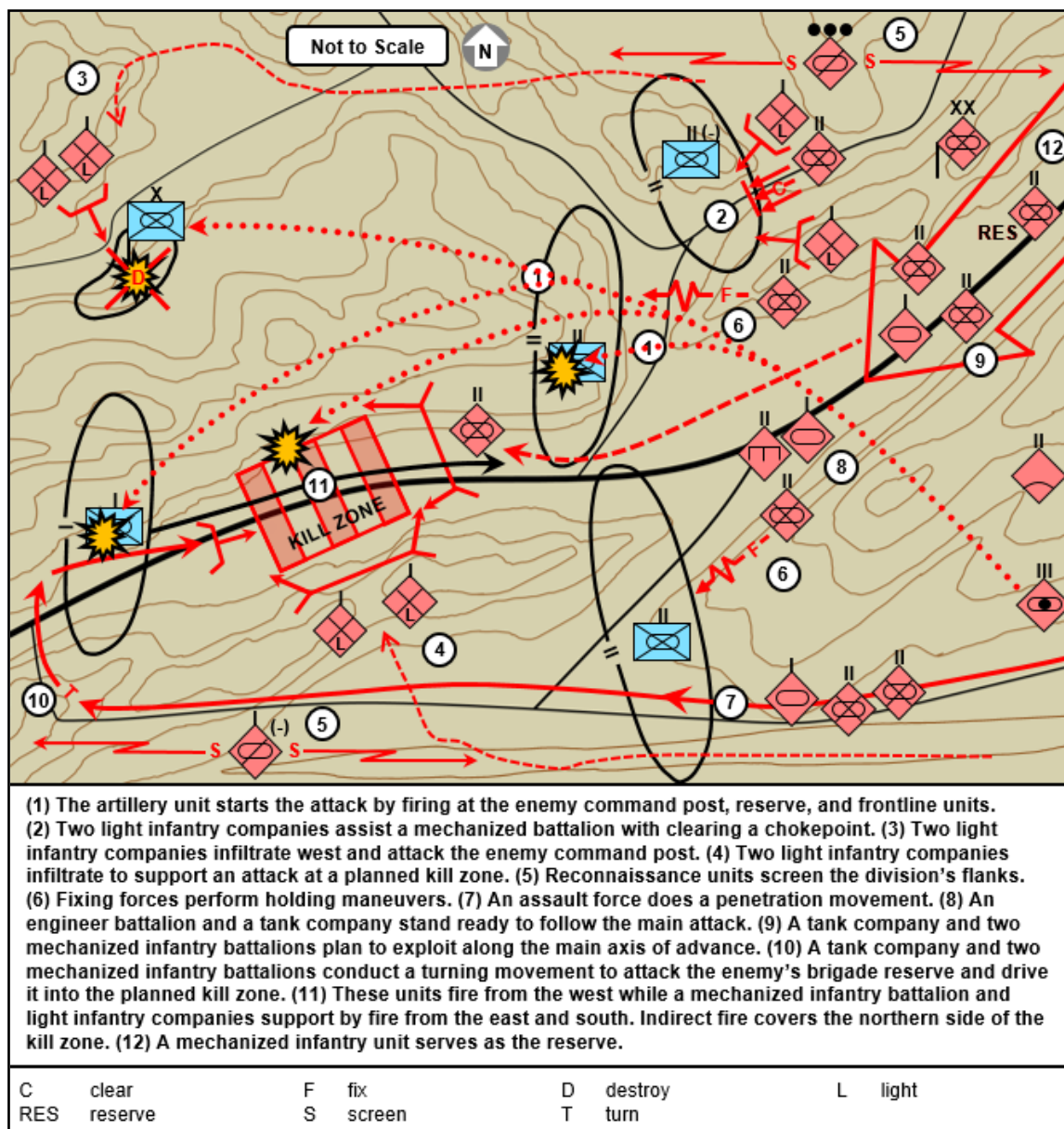


Figure 6-9. Integrated attack (KPAGF mechanized division-level encirclement example)

6-55. A KPAGF division typically uses its light infantry units on infiltration missions to initiate the attack during the night, inclement weather, or poor visibility conditions. All six light infantry companies in this example take part in the integrated attack, but support three different offensive actions. On the western flank, two light infantry companies (#2) assist the mechanized battalion to clear a mountain pass chokepoint (#3). The units' task is to conduct a thrust attack to clear the pass in order to gain freedom of movement and allow possible exploitation from second-echelon units.

6-56. Two other light infantry companies on the same flank infiltrate (#4) farther to the south to attack the enemy's brigade CP (#5) by fire in order to destroy it, if not already destroyed by KPAGF artillery fire. On the eastern flank, the remainder of the light infantry battalion—two companies—infiltrates (#6) to serve as the support unit (#7) on the eastern flank of a planned kill zone.

6-57. Even though there are adjacent KPAGF divisions also attacking, the majority of the KPAGF division's reconnaissance company (#8) still protects the eastern flank of the main attack with a screen, especially as the main assault force makes its turning movement to the west and then north again (#16). A single reconnaissance platoon (#9) screens the division's western flank to prevent a surprise attack from the adjacent KPAGF division's AO.

6-58. Away from the main attack and the light infantry battalion activities, there are three other supporting attacks occurring almost simultaneously. These include the thrust attack (#3) on the western flank already mentioned above, two holding maneuvers (#10 and #11) by fixing forces to the east and west of the main attack, and a penetration movement (#12) to the east of the main attack. The engineer battalion and the first-echelon tank company (#13) are prepared to follow the main attack along the major road or along possible secondary avenues of approach to the east. The engineer battalion is prepared to assist with any breach operations required along the main axis of advance or the secondary axis, located to the east.

6-59. The second-echelon units (#14), consisting of a tank company and two mechanized infantry battalions, serve as the KPAGF's divisional exploitation force and are at a far enough distance to follow whichever first-echelon unit is most successful. The planned exploitation is along the main axis of advance (#15), but could possibly go through the cleared chokepoint to the west (#3) or, if the penetration attack has been more successful than the main attack, farther to the east (#12). In the tradition of old Soviet/Russian doctrine, the KPAGF will reinforce success, and any KPAGF division plan will contain different route options for the second-echelon units to follow based on the success of the first-echelon units.

6-60. The KPAGF main attack has many moving parts. A single tank company and two mechanized infantry battalions (the assault force) would then conduct a turning movement (#16) from the east to attack the enemy's brigade reserve (#17) from the south. Its task is to get behind the enemy's brigade reserve in order to drive it into the planned kill zone (#18). If possible, the timing of this attack would occur shortly after the brigade reserve initiated movement from its assembly area to reinforce a gap in the front lines to its north.

6-61. The planned KPAGF kill zone (#18) is located between the enemy's frontline units and its reserve force (#17). If executed correctly, the KPAGF tank company and two mechanized infantry battalions would attack by fire from the south (#19); one mechanized infantry battalion with possibly a tank company would support by fire (#20) from the north. The intent is for the main assault force to annihilate the brigade reserve at its most vulnerable time, the moment it begins its movement from the reserve assembly area.

6-62. The two KPAGF light infantry companies that infiltrated earlier would support by fire (#7) from the east to prevent the enemy reserve from escaping in that direction. The kill zone's fourth flank, to the west, is blocked by high ground. If necessary, indirect fire from artillery and rockets in the division artillery group (#21) could cover the western flank area not covered by direct fire from ground units. In addition to the second-echelon units designated to exploit the success of the first-echelon assaults (#14), the KPAGF division will keep approximately one battalion in reserve (#22) for other contingencies. The division's organic air defense battalion will provide sector coverage for the AO.

6-63. Upon completion of the encirclement of the enemy brigade reserve and any frontline units falling back into the kill zone and their subsequent annihilation, the KPAGF division would continue its movement to the south. Based on its experiences during the Korean War, KPAGF commanders expect that a significant penetration of the enemy's front lines will cause adjacent enemy units to also conduct retrograde operations to maintain contact with their flanks and to avoid being cut off.

6-64. If the first-echelon KPAGF units still maintain adequate forces, these would continue to press the attack southward. If not strong enough to remain a viable force, or based on the situation, the KPAGF division's second-echelon forces could then pass through the first echelon to attack the enemy's combat support, combat service support, C2, and communications units in the enemy's divisional or corps rear area.

Functional Organization for an Integrated Attack

6-65. An integrated attack employs various types of functional units. The tactical KPAGF commander assigns subordinate units functional designations corresponding to their intended roles in the attack.

Enabling Forces

6-66. An integrated attack often employs fixing, assault, and support forces. A disruption force exists, but is not created specifically for this type of offensive action.

6-67. The fixing force prevents enemy defending, reserve, and quick-response forces from interfering with the actions of the assault and exploitation forces. The mission task to fix a designated enemy force can be time-related or when relieved of the task by the KPAGF commander. One or more fixing forces can be employed during the attack.

6-68. The assault force is charged with destroying a particular enemy force or seizing key terrain. The assault or assaults can create a tactical opportunity for an exploitation force. The commander may employ one or more assault forces.

6-69. A support force provides the assaulting unit with one or more of the following, including but not limited to—

- C2 and communications.
- Rear service units.
- Direct fire support.
- Indirect fire support.
- Mobility support.
- EIW support.

Action Force

6-70. The most common type of action force in an integrated attack is the exploitation (second tactical echelon) force. This force must be capable of penetrating or avoiding enemy defensive forces and destroying targeted critical components of the enemy combat system. An exploitation force typically possesses a task-organized combination of mobility, protection, and firepower to accomplish the assigned exploitation objective.

Dispersed Attack

6-71. Dispersed attack is an offensive action in which the KPAGF conducts offensive actions when threatened by a superior enemy or when unable to mass or provide integrated C2 and communications to an attack. While a unit of any size can conduct a dispersed attack, it will likely be conducted by a company or larger. The primary objective of dispersed attack is to create tactical opportunities to destroy the enemy's will or capability to continue armed conflict. Dispersed attack relies on dispersion of units and EIW effects to conduct tactical offensive actions when overmatched by an enemy. To achieve this, the KPAGF does not necessarily have to destroy the entire enemy force, but often only destroy or degrade key components of the enemy's combat system.

6-72. The KPAGF dispersed attack concept is to conduct recurring attacks in varied timing and multiple locations to degrade vulnerable enemy capabilities. A dispersed attack can be used against peer forces when tactical opportunities emerge and support the gradual defeat of the enemy combat system. Figure 6-10 is an example of a dispersed attack by KPA special operations forces (SOF) with assistance from North Korean clandestine supporters already living in South Korea. A subordinate unit could also conduct a dispersed attack as part of its higher unit's integrated attack. Number 3 in figure 6-9 on page 6-16 provides an example of a unit conducting a dispersed attack while the higher KPAGF unit conducts an integrated attack.

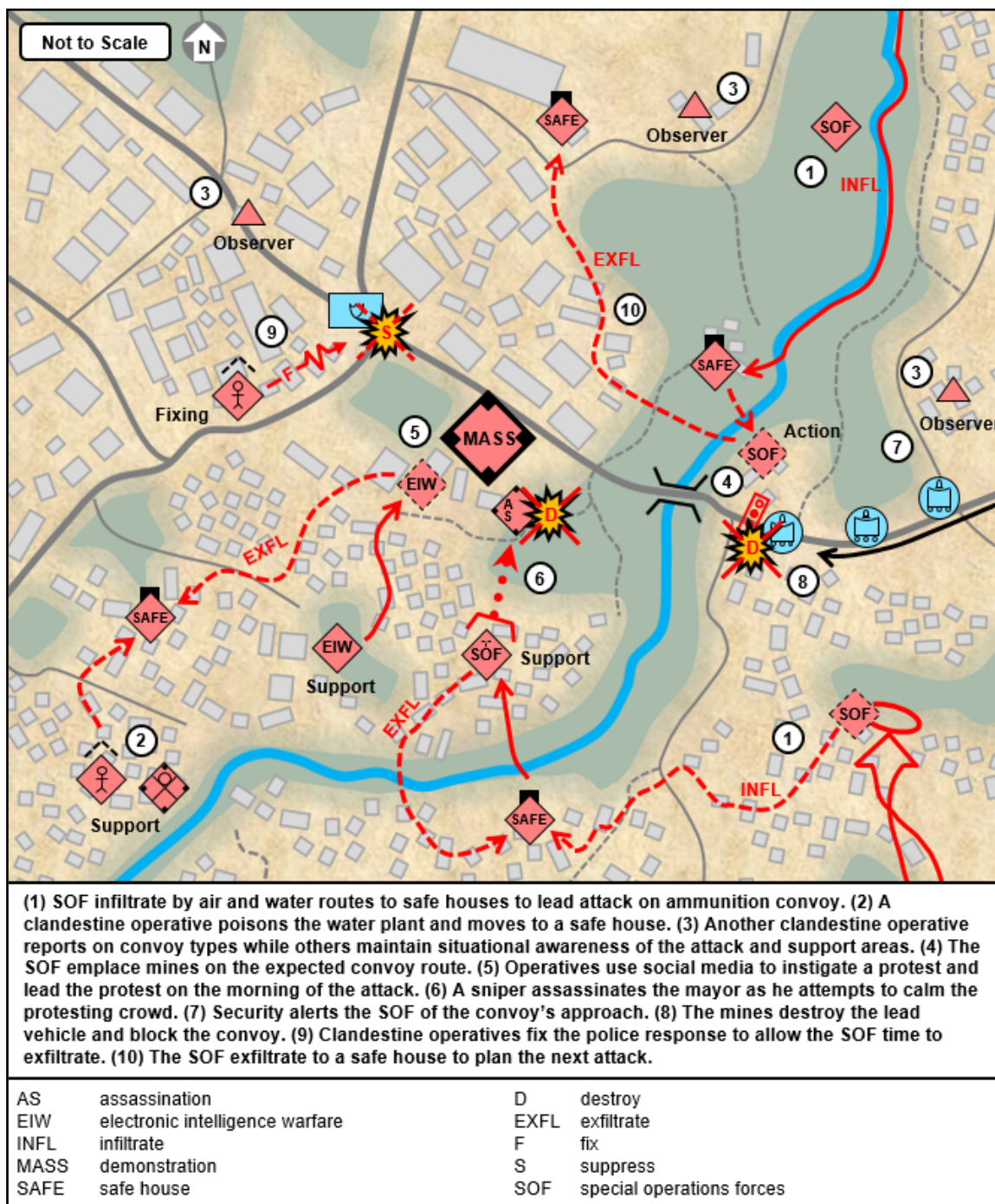


Figure 6-10. Dispersed attack (example)

6-73. Dispersed attacks are characterized by the following activities:

- Degrade enemy situational understanding with EIW elements.
- Target and focus attacks on key components of the enemy's combat system.
- Conduct rapid massing and use of combat power, followed by rapid dispersal.
- Disrupt enemy forces with reinforced complex terrain and disruption forces.
- Fix designated enemy forces.

- Isolate targeted critical components of the enemy combat system.
 - Conduct recurring attacks on critical components of the enemy combat system.
 - Defeat enemy will and resolve with EIW.
 - Destroy enemy will and resolve to continue armed conflict.
- 6-74. To establish tactical conditions favorable for dispersed attack, actions include but are not limited to—
- Destroy enemy ground reconnaissance.
 - Deceive enemy imagery and signals sensors.
 - Create a vulnerable air defense environment.
 - Deceive the enemy regarding situational awareness and understanding.
 - Optimize use of complex terrain.

Functional Organization for a Dispersed Attack

6-75. A dispersed attack employs various types of functional units. The KPAGF commander assigns subordinate units functional designations corresponding to their intended roles in the attack.

Enabling Forces

6-76. A dispersed attack often employs fixing, assault, and support forces. A disruption force may exist, but is not created specifically for this type of offensive action. Deception forces can also play an important role in a dispersed attack.

6-77. The fixing force fixes enemy defending forces, reserves, or quick-response forces to prevent them from interfering with the actions of the assault and exploitation forces. The mission task to fix a designated enemy force can be time-related or when relieved of the task by the KPAGF commander. One or more fixing forces can be employed during the attack.

6-78. The assault force is charged with destroying a particular part of the enemy force or seizing key positions. Such an assault can create favorable conditions for the exploitation force to rapidly move from dispersed locations and penetrate or infiltrate enemy defenses. The commander may employ one or more assault forces.

6-79. A support force provides support throughout multiple dispersed sites in an AO. Support includes one or more of the following but is not limited to—

- C2 and communications.
- Rear service units.
- Direct fire support.
- Indirect fire support.
- Mobility support.
- EIW support.

Action Force

6-80. The most common type of action force in an integrated attack is the exploitation force. This force must be capable of destroying the target of the attack. An exploitation force can be a dispersed group of forces conducting multiple attacks progressively or simultaneously on designated targets or objectives.

LIMITED-OBJECTIVE ATTACK

6-81. A limited-objective attack achieves results critical to tactical operations by denying critical capabilities to the enemy. The results of a KPAGF limited-objective attack typically support the overall success of KPAGF operations, preserve KPAGF combat power, and degrade enemy capabilities. The primary objective of a limited-objective attack is to degrade a particular enemy capability, system, or group of systems, but can also be to disrupt the enemy tempo of operations.

6-82. Limited-objective attacks are characterized by actions to—

- Focus on disruption or destruction of a designated target or objective.
- Fix designated enemy forces.
- Isolate targeted critical components of the enemy combat system.
- Optimize use of systems warfare.
- Deny the enemy a particular capability.

6-83. There are two types of tactical limited-objective attacks: spoiling attack and counterattack. These share some common characteristics but differ in tactical purpose.

Spoiling Attack (Attack Against an Attacking Enemy)

6-84. The purpose of a KPAGF spoiling attack is to preempt or seriously disrupt an enemy attack while the enemy is in the process of planning, forming, assembling, or preparing to attack. A spoiling attack can also affect enemy defensive operations by disrupting the tempo of related enemy activities. The spoiling attack is designed to disrupt or deny enemy actions favorable to conducting an enemy attack.

6-85. Spoiling attacks are characterized with actions that—

- Confirm intelligence of enemy tactical plans or preparations.
- Identify a critical enemy vulnerability.
- Indicate a timely and rapid action to counter enemy plans or preparations.
- Retain or regain the tactical initiative.

6-86. The KPAGF shape the following conditions for a spoiling attack with—

- Reconnaissance, intelligence, and surveillance of enemy attack preparations.
- Target acquisition of enemy security, reserve, and response forces that could possibly disrupt the spoiling attack.
- Fixing designated enemy forces.
- Isolating targeted critical components of the enemy combat system.
- Denying, defeating, or destroying the enemy or a particular capability.

Counterattack

6-87. A counterattack is a KPAGF offensive action by a designated force against an enemy attacking force with the aim of denying the enemy its tactical objective. Typically a mission task initiated by a KPAGF defending force, it causes an enemy offensive action to culminate and allows the KPAGF to control the tempo of operations and retain or regain the tactical initiative. The KPA emphasizes to its commanders to counterattack as quickly as possible to prevent the enemy from solidifying its position and to catch it where it is the weakest physically and logistically. The KPAGF will often conduct a counterattack when the commander believes the enemy forces do not possess adequate support or are disorganized. Counterattacks can be conducted by all sizes of KPAGF units from company to regiment. During the counterattack, the KPAGF counterattack force could use any of the seven forms of maneuver previously discussed. The KPAGF counterattack will rarely extend beyond the limit of any supporting weapons.

6-88. The KPAGF conducts counterattacks to—

- Slow the enemy's advance.
- Annihilate a portion of the attacking force.
- Recapture a lost position.

6-89. Counterattacks are characterized by—

- A shift in command and support relationships to assume an offensive posture for the counterattacking force.
- Proper identification that the enemy is at or near culmination.
- Planned rapid transition of the remainder of the force to the offense.
- The possibility that a counterattack may open a window of opportunity for other combat actions.

6-90. The KPAGF seek to set the following conditions for a counterattack:

- Locate and track enemy reserve forces and cause them to be committed.
- Destroy enemy reconnaissance forces that could observe counterattack preparations.
- Begin the counterattack at night, to be completed by midnight, so gains can be consolidated before daybreak.

Functional Organization for a Limited-objective Attack

6-91. Functional organization for a limited-objective attack may appear similar to either an integrated or dispersed attack. The functions of forces may differ, however, based on the tactical conditions. A spoiling attack could be ordered during offensive or defensive operations, while a counterattack would typically be ordered for execution only from a defensive operation. Limited-objective attacks are characterized by actions to—

- Focus on disruption or destruction of a designated target or objective.
- Fix designated enemy forces.
- Isolate targeted critical components of the enemy combat system.
- Optimize use of systems warfare.
- Attack to deny the enemy a particular capability or disrupt enemy tempo.

6-92. **Action Forces.** The most common type of action force in a limited-objective attack is an assault force or exploitation force. The primary purpose of the mission task is the description assigned to the action force.

6-93. **Enabling Forces.** A counterattack often employs fixing, assault, and support forces. If a disruption force is utilized, the units used are normally ones that were part of a previous KPAGF defensive posture. It is unlikely that the KPAGF commander will receive additional external forces in order to execute a counterattack.

6-94. The fixing force in a counterattack is the part of the force engaged in defensive action with the enemy. This force continues to fight from its current position and seeks to account for the key parts of the enemy array and ensure they are not able to break contact and reposition. Additionally, the fixing force has the mission of making contact with and destroying enemy reconnaissance forces and any combat forces that may have penetrated the KPAGF defense.

6-95. The assault force, an enabler when supporting an exploitation force, can be assigned tasks of forcing a penetration of enemy forces, continuing the assault, causing commitment of enemy reserves, or similar actions fixing enemy forces and degrading enemy reaction to an exploitation force.

6-96. A support force provides task-organized combat support, rear service, C2, or communications functions. Other specialized support is mission dependent.

TACTICAL OFFENSIVE ACTIONS—DETACHMENTS, BATTALIONS, AND SUBORDINATE UNITS

6-97. KPAGF commanders of detachments, battalions, and subordinate units are tasked to conduct offensive actions with a mission purpose and intent. KPAGF units at this tactical level typically execute only one tactical mission at a time. Conducting simultaneous multiple missions by a detachment or subordinate-type element would be rare. If simultaneous multiple missions are required as part of a larger mission set, more than one detachment or tactical unit will be tasked and organized for actions within the larger mission.

FUNCTIONAL ORGANIZATION OF OFFENSIVE ELEMENTS

6-98. At the detachment, battalion, and subordinate unit level, functional organizations are called elements, rather than the force descriptor used at divisional or regimental level.

6-99. An action element typically is an assault, ambush, or raid element. In a reconnaissance attack, however, the action element typically changes during the mission. This is due to the multiple actions required to find and fix selected enemy units and set conditions for a mission leader to order a decisive action, such as an attack, assault, ambush, or raid.

Note. Any battalion or company receiving additional assets from a higher command becomes a battalion-size detachment or company-size detachment. References to a detachment throughout this chapter may also apply to a battalion, company, or subordinate unit unless specifically stated otherwise.

ASSAULT

6-100. An assault is an attack that destroys an enemy unit through firepower and the physical occupation or destruction of a position. An assault is a basic form of KPAGF tactical offensive combat.

6-101. Other types of offensive action may include an element conducting an assault to complete a mission; however, that action will be given a designation corresponding to the specific mission accomplished. For example, an element conducting an assault as part of the action element of an ambush would still be designated as an ambush element. Figure 6-11 on page 6-24 provides an example of a simple assault.

Functional Organization for an Assault

6-102. A detachment conducting an ambush typically is organized into three elements: the assault element, the security element, and the support element. There may be more than one of each of these types of element.

6-103. The assault element is the action element. It maneuvers to and seizes the enemy position, and defeats or destroys any enemy units at the objective.

6-104. The security element provides early warning of approaching enemy units and prevents them from reinforcing the assaulted position or unit. The KPAGF commander may accept risk and employ a security element that can only provide early warning, but is not strong enough to halt or repel enemy response elements. Security elements can provide reconnaissance, security, and counterreconnaissance.

6-105. The support element provides the assaulting detachment with one or more of the following, including but not limited to—

- C2 and communications.
- Rear service units.
- Direct fire support.
- Indirect fire support.
- Mobility support.
- EIW support.

Organizing for an Assault

6-106. The detachment conducting an assault is assigned an AO and objective. A key coordination point with respect to the AO is whether a higher headquarters is controlling the airspace associated with the assault.

Executing an Assault

6-107. An assault is typically an integrated combined arms approach. KPAGF assaults are characterized with actions to—

- Conduct tactical security.
- Isolate the objective.
- Fix designated enemy elements.
- Suppress the objective with fires.
- Maneuver to seize the objective.

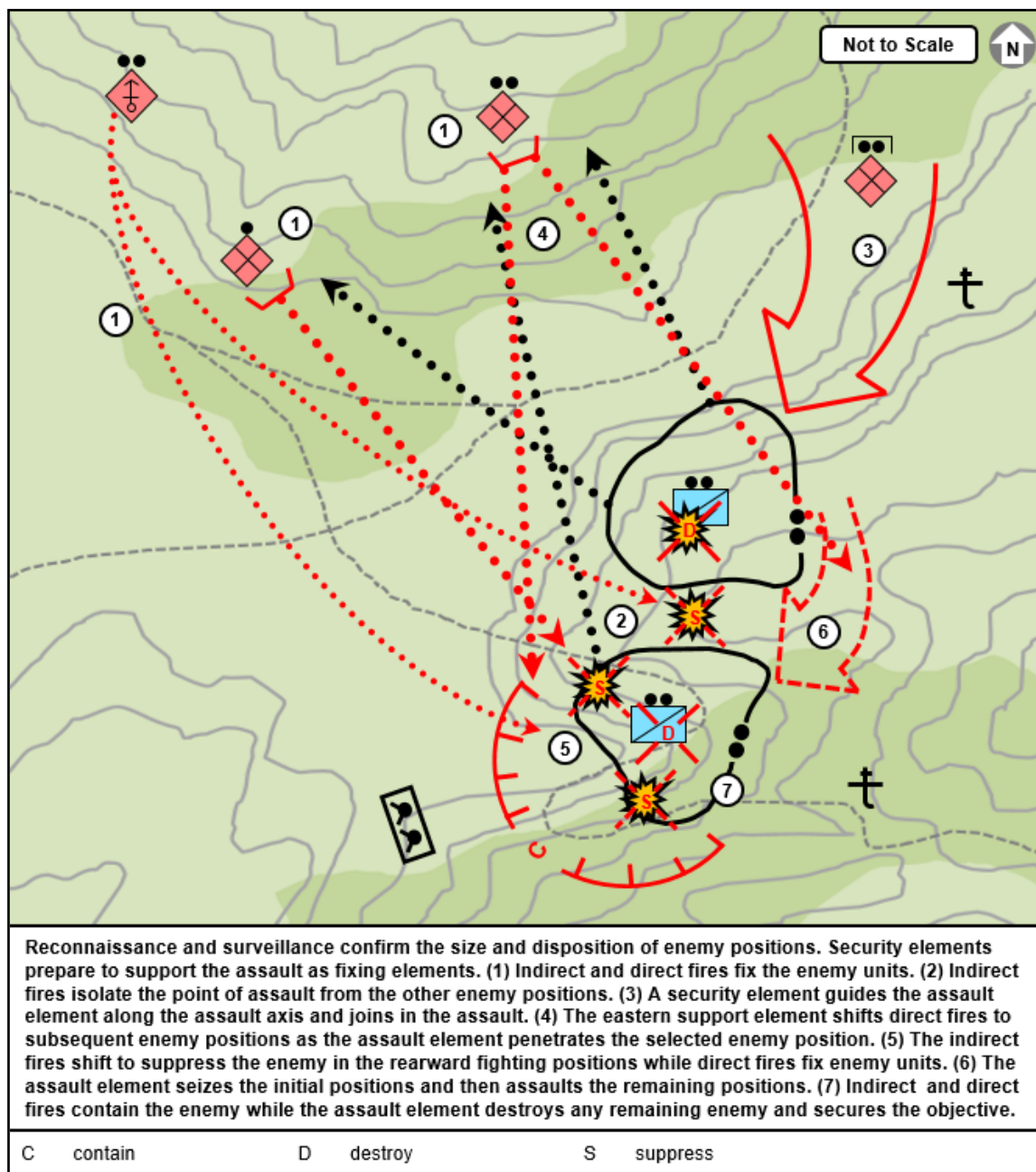


Figure 6-11. Assault (example)

6-108. **Assault Element.** The assault element is the action element. Actions center on maneuver, supported by fires, from an assault position to and beyond the objective. Typical tactical tasks expected of the assault element are—

- Clear.
- Destroy.
- Occupy.
- Secure.
- Seize.

Speed of execution is critical to an assault. The assault element will use surprise and situational factors of limited visibility and complex terrain, as well as camouflage, concealment, cover, and deception.

6-109. **Security Element.** The security element is typically the first element to act in an assault. It moves to a position(s) to deny the enemy freedom of movement along any ground or air avenues of approach that can reinforce the objective or interfere with the mission of the assault element. The security element can be directed to perform other tactical tasks to include—

- Ambush.
- Block.
- Canalize.
- Delay.
- Disrupt.
- Fix.
- Contain (this task usually requires multiple elements.)
- Isolate (this task usually requires multiple elements.)
- Destroy.

6-110. **Support Element.** The support element can have a wide range of functions in an assault. The detachment commander typically exercises C2 from within a part of the support element, unless analysis deems that success requires the commander to lead the assault element personally.

AMBUSH

6-111. An *ambush* is an attack by fire or other destructive means from concealed positions on a moving or temporarily halted enemy (FM 3-90-1). In an ambush, enemy action determines the time of attack, whereas the KPA GF unit sets the location. Figure 6-12 on page 6-26 provides an example of an ambush. Ambush effects can include but are not limited to—

- Destroy or capture personnel and supplies.
- Harass and demoralize the enemy.
- Delay or block movement of personnel and supplies.
- Canalize enemy movement by making certain routes unavailable for traffic.

6-112. The KPA GF can use an ambush as a psychological warfare enabler. Key factors in an ambush are—

- Surprise.
- Control.
- Simplicity.
- Security.
- Coordinated fires.
- Withdrawal.

Functional Organization for an Ambush

6-113. A detachment conducting an ambush is typically organized into three elements: the ambush element, the security element, and the support element. There may be more than one of each of these types of element. The composition of these elements may vary depending on the mission. The type of units could involve infantry, reconnaissance, armor, antiarmor, air defense, or engineer, but are not limited to those listed.

6-114. **Action Element.** The ambush element is the action element. The ambush element attacks to defeat or destroy enemy units in a kill zone. An ambush can be a primary or complementary action to prevent an enemy from accomplishing its mission.

6-115. **Security Element.** The security element has the mission to prevent enemy units from responding to the ambush before completion of the attack. The element provides early warning, prevents the ambush element from becoming decisively engaged, and supports effective withdrawal of all ambush elements from the ambush site.

6-116. **Support Element.** The support element of an ambush has the same basic functions as one for an assault. Typically, the detachment commander exercises C2 from within a part of the support element.

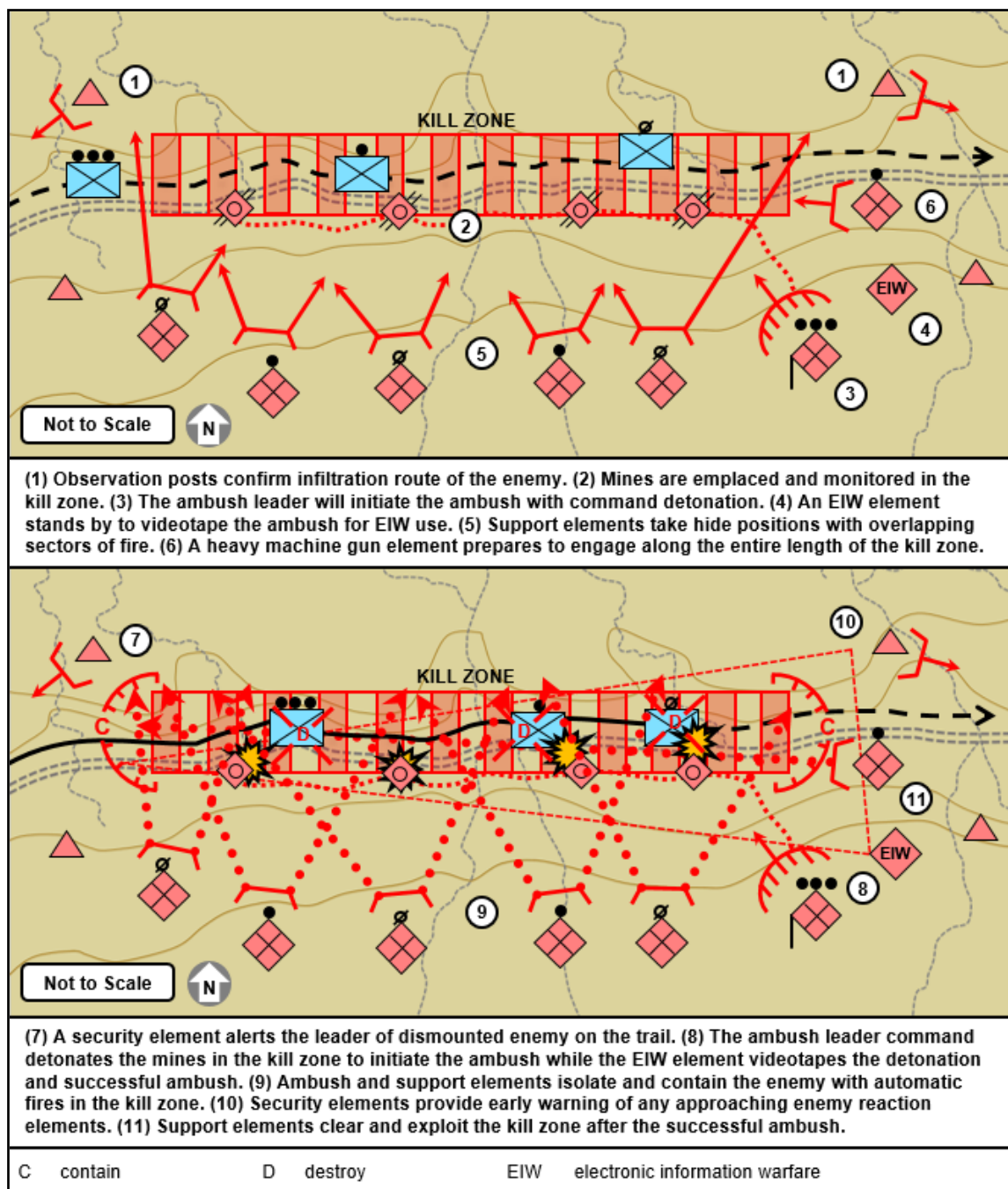


Figure 6-12. Ambush (example)

Organizing for an Ambush

6-117. The planning and preparation of an ambush is concentrated on massing combat power into a kill zone. One or more kill zones can be employed depending on the terrain, expected size of the enemy, and KPAGF combat systems coverage of the kill zone. Firing positions provide concealment, cover, and

favorable fields of fire into the kill zone. Manmade obstacles reinforce the restrictions of natural obstacles and the terrain.

Executing an Ambush

6-118. At a C2 signal or terrain-oriented point, the ambush element engages the enemy in the kill zone. Security elements engage any enemy elements not in the kill zone. After the enemy has been rendered combat ineffective, designated ambush or support elements exploit the objective area and kill zone, and then withdraw to a rally point. The KPA places emphasis on intelligence collection and the retrieval of weapons and other equipment of value by the ambush element. Successful execution of an ambush focuses on the desired effects in the mission order, which can include harassment, seizing prisoners, or annihilation of enemy elements.

RAID

6-119. A raid is an attack to temporarily seize a stationary or moving target in order to capture or destroy personnel or equipment. Raids can also be tasked to secure selective information or deceive an enemy. A raid concludes with the withdrawal of the raiding detachment to sanctuary. Figure 6-13 on page 6-28 provides an example of a KPAGF raid.

6-120. Raids are characterized by actions to include but not limited to—

- Destroy or damage key systems or facilities.
- Secure designated enemy materiel.
- Seize prisoners.
- Support EIW objectives.
- Support operations by creating a tactical opportunity for another KPAGF unit.

6-121. The raiding detachment typically consists of three elements: raiding, security, and support. Other functional elements may be task-organized dependent on the mission. The size of the raiding element depends upon its mission, the nature and location of the target, and the enemy situation. The composition of these elements may vary depending on the mission. The type of units could involve infantry, reconnaissance, armor, antiarmor, air defense, or engineer, but are not limited to those listed.

6-122. **Action Element.** The raiding element is the action element. It attacks to accomplish its assigned mission at a particular objective.

6-123. **Security Element.** The security element uses stealth to occupy positions in order to fix enemy security or response units that would disrupt the raiding element. Security tasks can include preventing enemy escape from the objective. The security element also protects the withdrawal as the other elements move to sanctuary.

6-124. The security element moves to positions to deny the enemy freedom of movement along any ground or air avenues of approach reinforcing the objective or interfere with the mission of the assault element. The security element can be directed to perform other tactical tasks to include—

- Ambush.
- Block.
- Canalize.
- Delay.
- Fix.
- Contain (this task usually requires multiple elements).
- Isolate (this task usually requires multiple elements).
- Destroy.

6-125. **Support Element.** The support element of an ambush has the same basic functions as in an assault. Typically, the detachment commander exercises C2 from within a part of the support element.

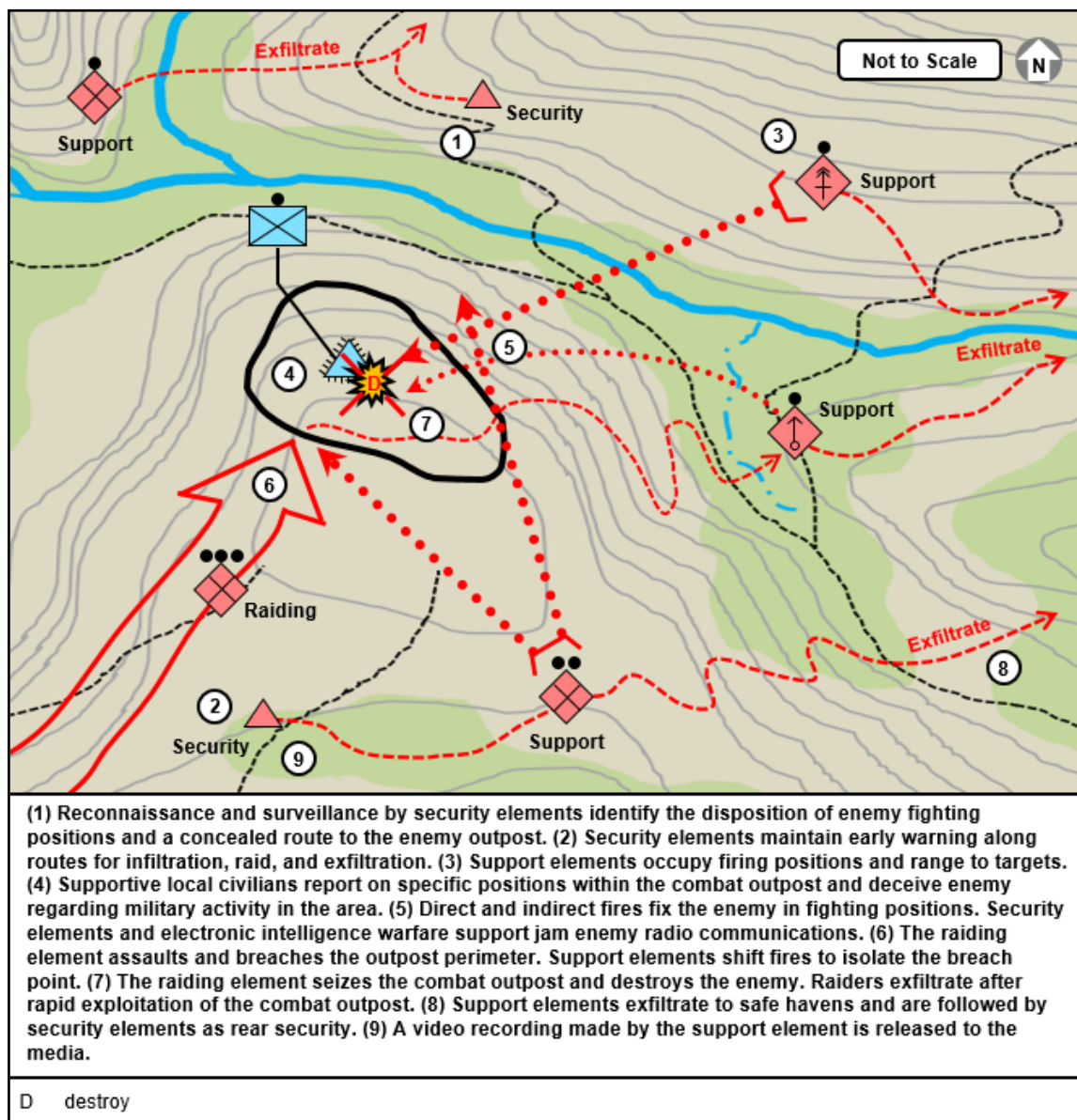


Figure 6-13. Raid (example)

RECONNAISSANCE ATTACK

6-126. A reconnaissance attack is a tactical offensive action to confirm situational understanding of an enemy's location, disposition, and actions in order to fix, defeat, or destroy a designated enemy. This offensive action can be used to gain specified information and intelligence on an enemy's capabilities and intentions for KPAGF tactical advantage in a future mission.

6-127. The KPAGF fights for information when necessary to retain or regain the initiative. A reconnaissance attack integrates a complex set of mission tasks, and can be employed when other means do not provide accurate situational understanding of an enemy and AO.

6-128. Key factors in employing a reconnaissance attack, as a complement to continuous aggressive reconnaissance, security, and related offensive actions, include but are not limited to—

- Situational awareness requirements of an evolving enemy presence or actions in an AO.
- Tempo of KPAGF conditional developments to regain situational understanding and tactical initiative.

Functional Organization for a Reconnaissance Attack

6-129. The detachment commander typically organizes a reconnaissance attack with reconnaissance, security, action, and support elements. More than one element of each functional type is typical in this mission due to the several simultaneous requirements and actions occurring in multiple zones within an AO.

Note. Based on the requirement for appropriate C2 of multiple functional elements in several simultaneous actions during the tactical phases of a reconnaissance attack, a company detachment is the smallest task-organized element to command a reconnaissance attack. The scope of this type of mission could require a C2 headquarters and a task-organized battalion or regiment.

6-130. **Reconnaissance Elements.** The reconnaissance attack employs several reconnaissance elements to confirm the location and actions of enemy units operating in the detachment's AO and conditions of an OE. If the mission purpose is to fix or destroy enemy units when located, reconnaissance elements provide reconnaissance support to other functional elements, such as security and actions elements.

6-131. **Security Elements.** Security elements operate in conjunction with reconnaissance elements, but also conduct reconnaissance tasks during the security mission. Upon locating an enemy unit and on order of the detachment commander, actions by security elements include but are not limited to—

- Fix or isolate designated enemy units.
- Block enemy reinforcement avenues of approach.
- Ambush enemy on withdrawal routes from a target or objective.
- Protect KPAGF elements during movements, maneuver, and follow-on mission tasks.

6-132. **Action Elements.** The action elements obtain a mission descriptor that most clearly identifies the primary action task. Actions can include mission tasks such as assault, ambush, or raid. The detachment commander monitors initial reconnaissance and security actions confirming the enemy situation, and then decides on actions to fix, isolate, defeat, or destroy a designated enemy unit.

6-133. **Support Elements.** Support elements are task-organized with particular capabilities and a priority of effort and support to designated functional elements in the reconnaissance attack detachment. The detachment commander locates C2 and communications nodes in the AO to most effectively receive and report timely reconnaissance and security indicators from the detachment elements. An extended depth and width of an AO may require a detachment CP well forward in the AO for reliable real-time information and intelligence.

Organizing for a Reconnaissance Attack

6-134. Multiple attack routes or axes often characterize reconnaissance attacks. There may also be objective rally points and orientation objectives.

Executing a Reconnaissance Attack

6-135. Multiple elements normally infiltrate or maneuver separately within an AO to find and report the current enemy situation. The detachment commander then directs when to fix, defeat, or destroy enemy units.

6-136. Initial supporting functions include multiple reconnaissance and security elements operating within designated zones of action to confirm the enemy situation. Other actions include reporting on the trafficability of routes and axes for follow-on movements and maneuver of the reconnaissance attack. Figure 6-14 on page 6-30 through figure 6-18 on page 6-34 provide an example of a KPAGF reconnaissance attack.

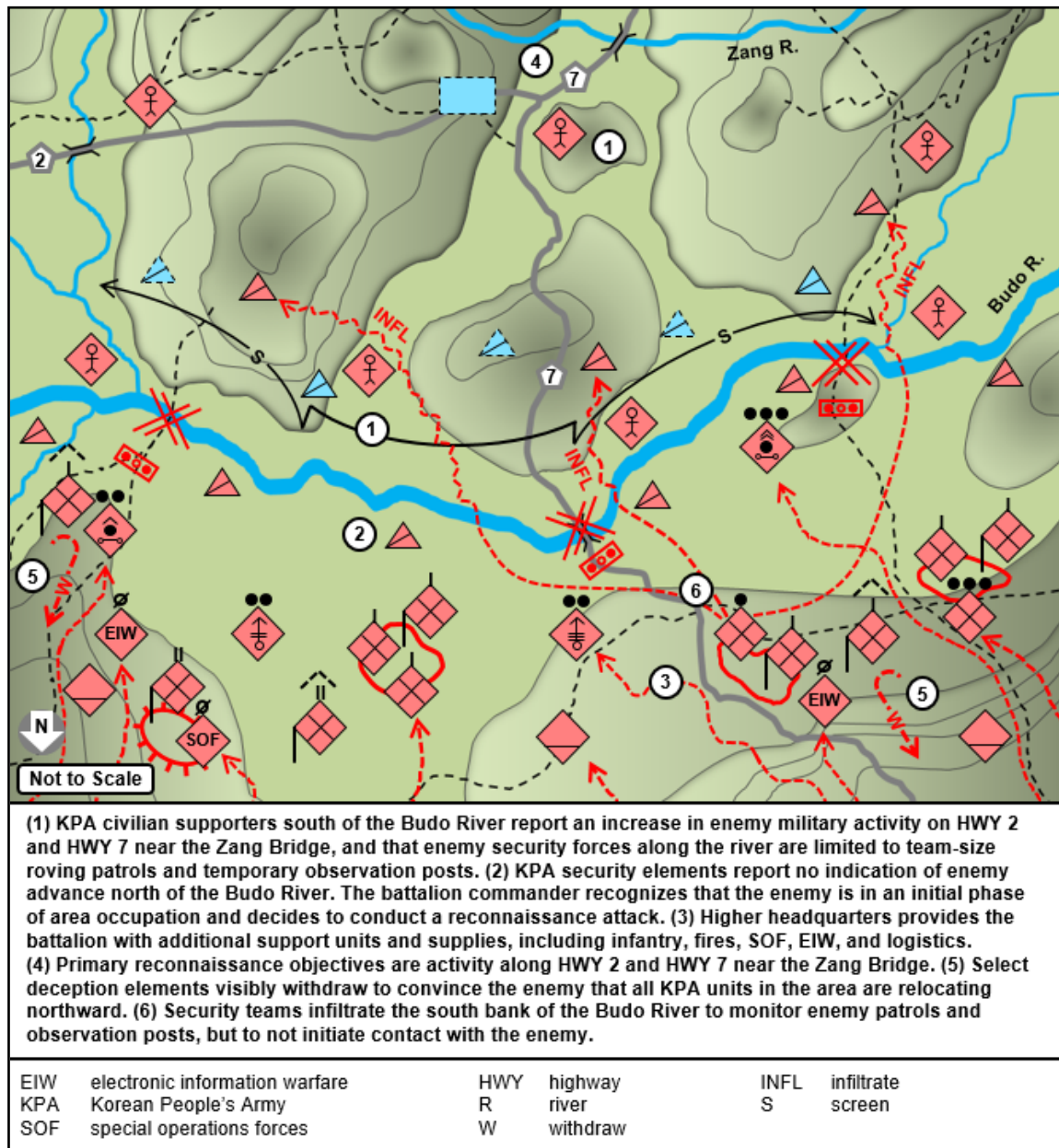


Figure 6-14. Reconnaissance attack (example; part 1 of 5)

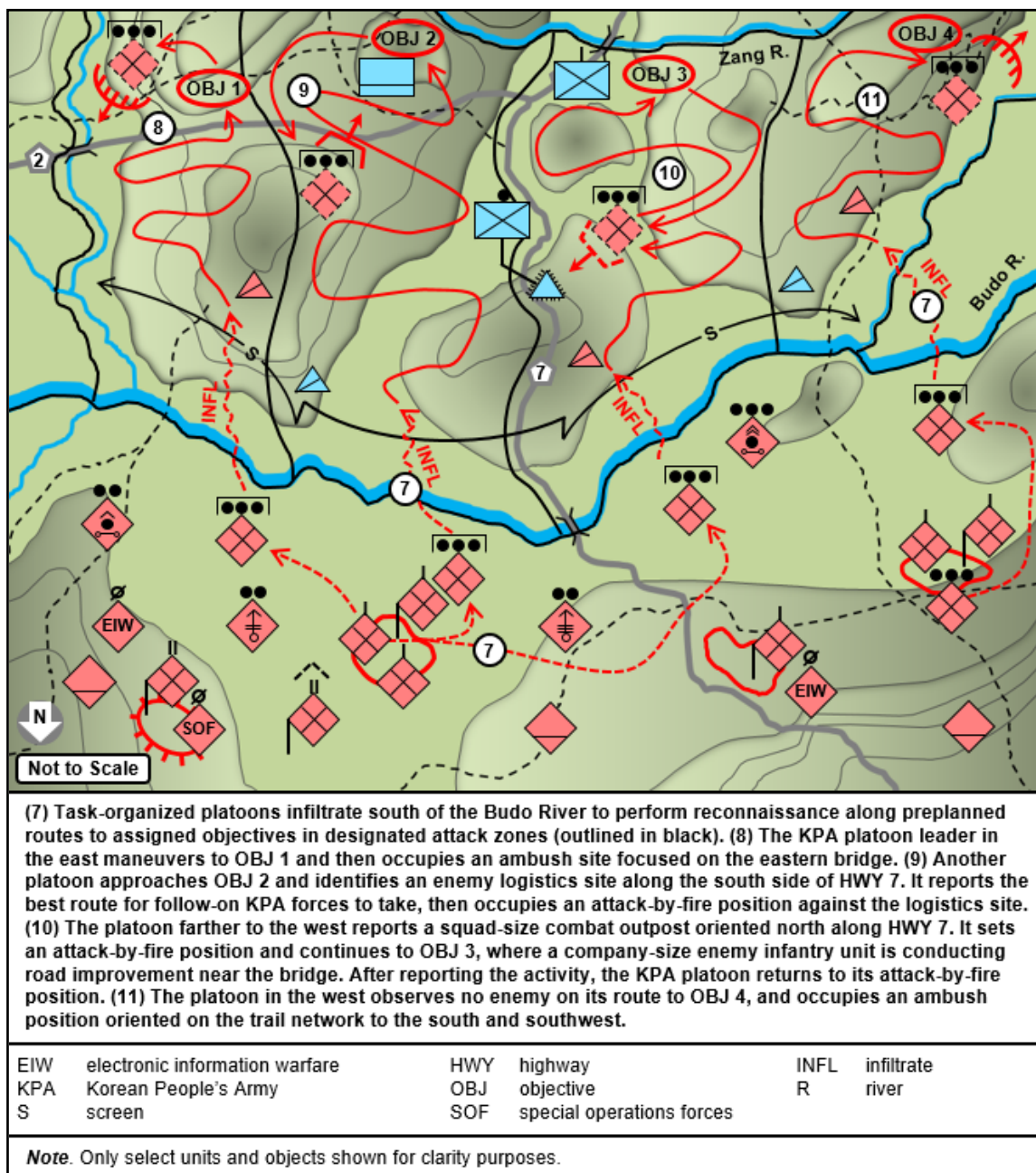


Figure 6-15. Reconnaissance attack (example; part 2 of 5)

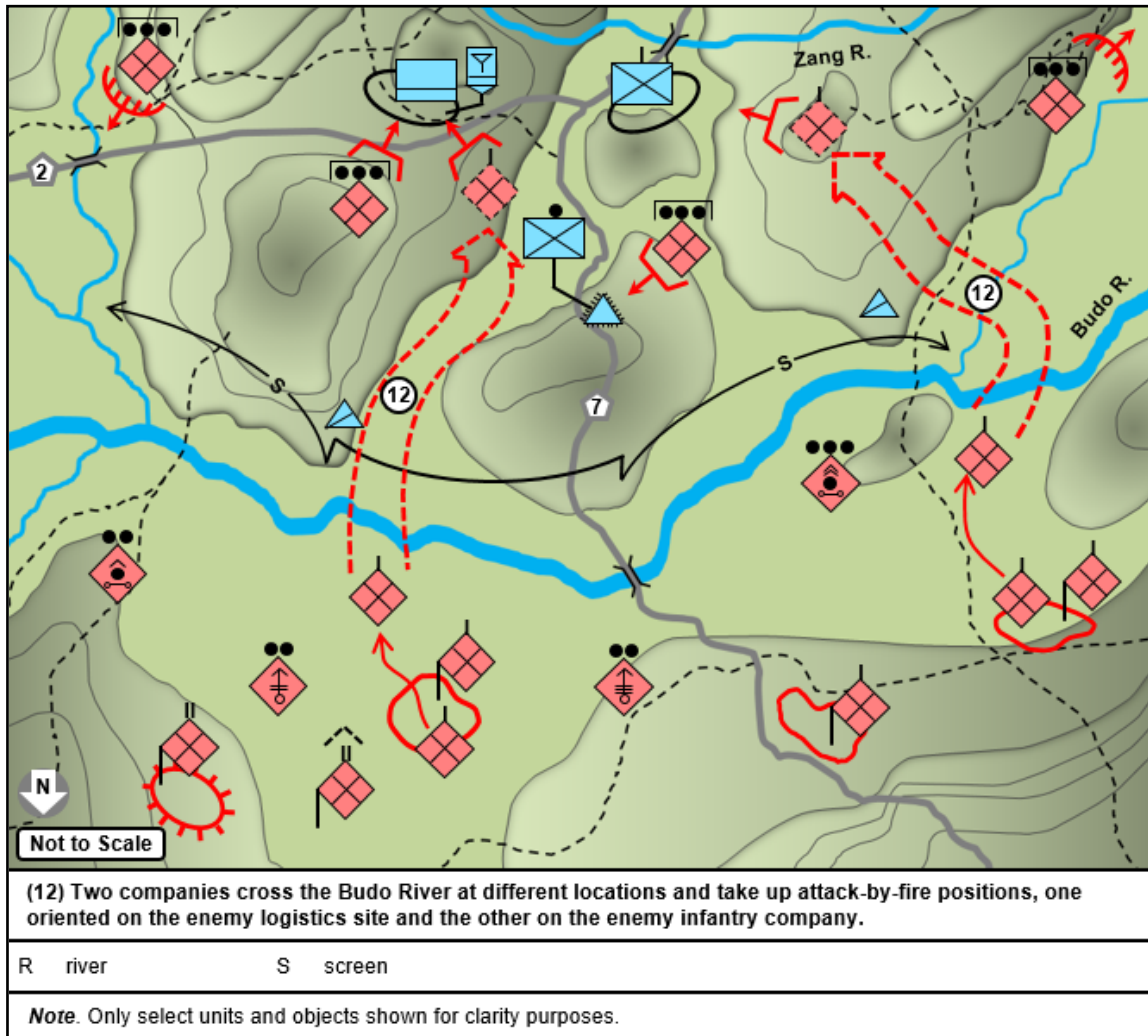


Figure 6-16. Reconnaissance attack (example; part 3 of 5)

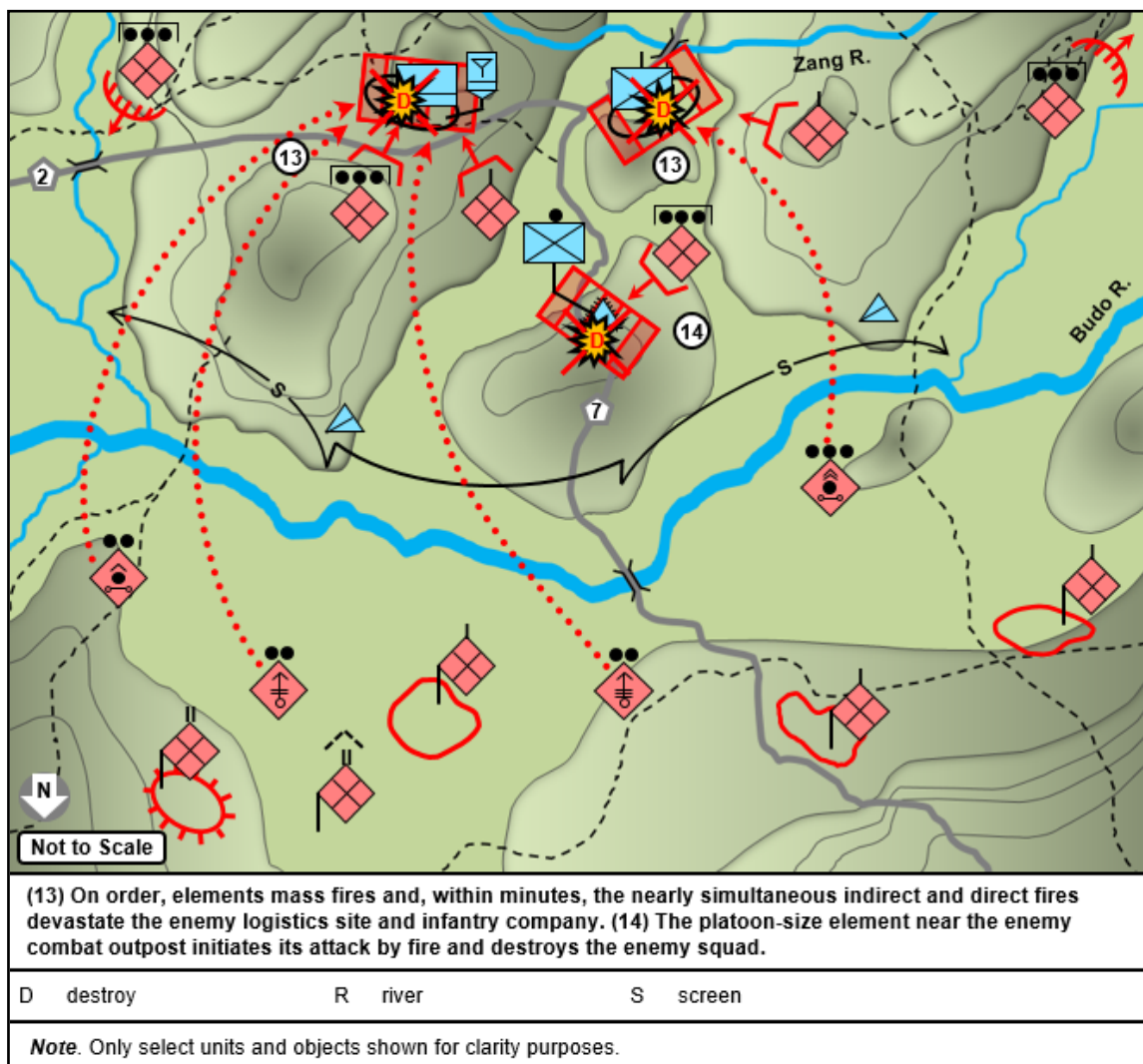


Figure 6-17. Reconnaissance attack (example; part 4 of 5)

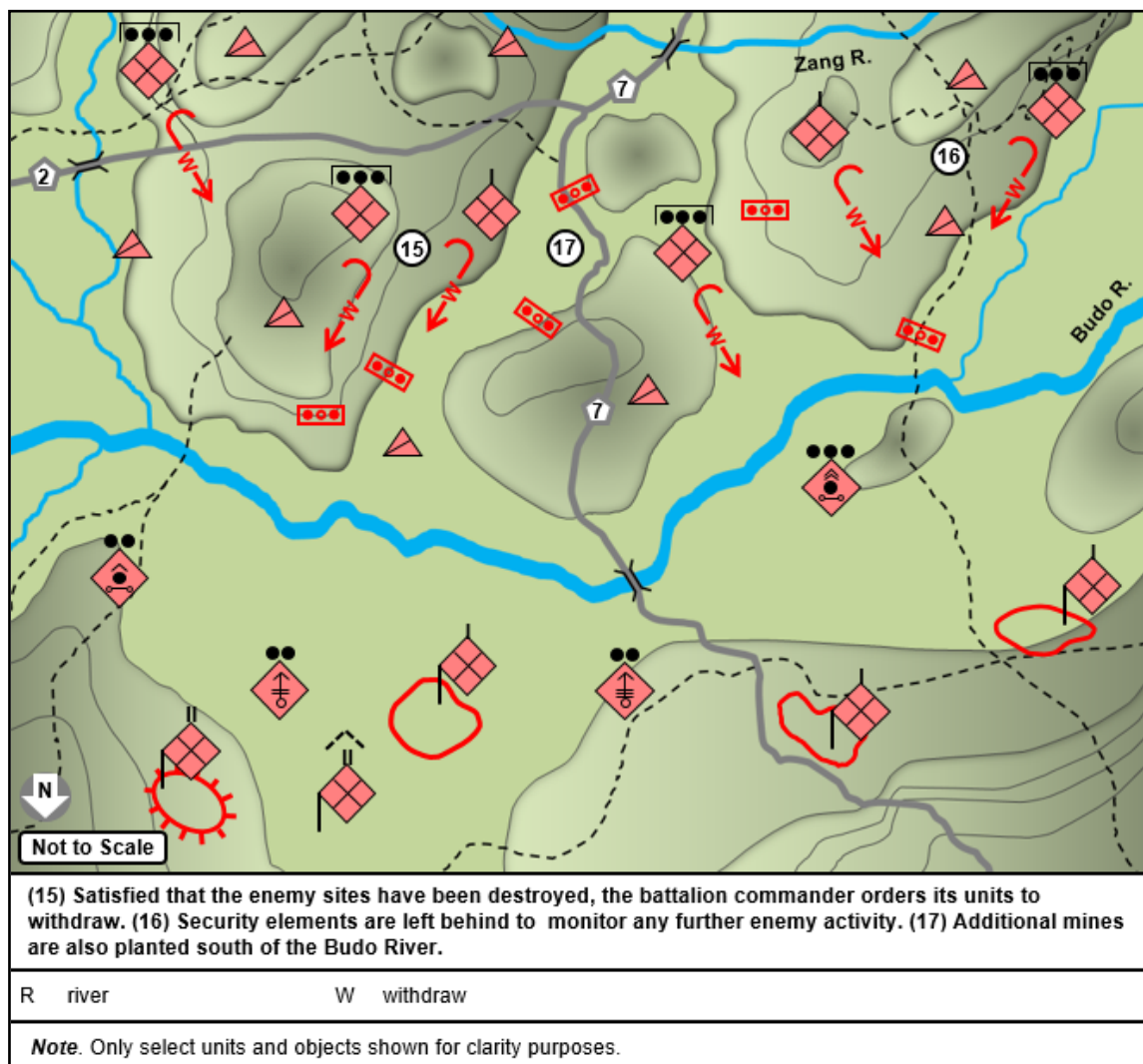


Figure 6-18. Reconnaissance attack (example; part 5 of 5)

Support of a Reconnaissance Attack

6-137. A reconnaissance attack requires multiple types of support collectively supporting KPAGF fires and maneuver in accomplishing the mission task. Support systems can include reconnaissance, security, direct and indirect fires support, aviation, air defense, engineer, logistics, and EIW.

Fires

6-138. Integrated fires support and integrated air defense provide responsive fires to all elements prior to and during the reconnaissance attack, and support the withdrawal of reconnaissance, security, action, or other support elements after completion of the mission. Fire support in a reconnaissance attack aims to—

- Protect reconnaissance and security elements in their zones.
- Protect action and support elements in maneuver or other offensive actions on enemy locations or terrain-oriented objectives.
- Suppress, neutralize, or destroy designated targets in an AO.

Aviation

6-139. Aviation elements can be task-organized and integrated into fires support, reconnaissance, security, or maneuver elements. Combat support and rear service aviation can also be task-organized in support. Due to the air superiority of its enemies, it is likely the KPA will only have the majority of its aviation elements available during the initial stages of any conflict. Aviation support will likely be rare in later military action.

Engineer

6-140. Engineer support focuses initially on mobility tasks to assist KPAGF movements and maneuver throughout the AO. Engineer units are also task-organized to conduct countermobility actions in support of tasks such as fix, block, or isolate designated enemy units during the reconnaissance attack.

Logistics

6-141. A reconnaissance attack typically has dispersed elements throughout an AO and often operates over extended time periods. The KPA positions task-organized logistics support with functional elements, and can create a system of logistics caches or mobile resupply points to sustain the elements during the mission.

Electronic Intelligence Warfare

6-142. EIW activities in a reconnaissance attack are primarily executed to—

- Protect KPA units from enemy detection.
- Deceive enemy units into revealing their actions and intentions.
- Assist in fixing or isolating enemy units.

OFFENSIVE OPERATIONS IN COMPLEX OPERATIONAL ENVIRONMENTS

6-143. The KPA expects to perform offensive operations in two primary types of complex OEs: urban and subterranean.

URBAN OPERATIONS

6-144. KPAGF offensive doctrine emphasizes speed in the attack. As such, the first operational echelon forces will likely bypass any major cities they encounter during offensive operations, leaving follow-on forces to deal with later. The KPAGF will likely isolate the bypassed cities to prevent assistance from the outside or a breakout from inside the urban area. The KPAGF has numerous small urban-warfare training facilities scattered throughout North Korea and at least one major army-level urban training facility to practice urban-warfare skills.

6-145. The major South Korean cities are densely packed urban environments with vast underground networks for communications, transportation, and utilities. There are over 320 km of track in the Seoul subway, with 70% of it located underground. There are also subways located in the four next-largest cities in South Korea: Busan, Incheon, Daegu, and Daejeon. These underground tunnels will serve as air raid shelters for local civilians.

6-146. If the KPAGF decided to conduct offensive operations in an urban area, the soldiers would face the same difficulties all military units face when confronted with operations within cities. It takes a large number of dismounted soldiers to clear each building before moving on to the next unsecured building.

SUBTERRANEAN OPERATIONS

6-147. U.S. and South Korean military units have discovered four infiltration tunnels reaching under South Korean territory. There may be other tunnels that could complement a KPAGF direct attack on South Korea. The existence of these tunnels became known in the mid-1970s when a KPAGF engineer defected to South Korea and disclosed the information during his debriefing. Of the four known tunnels, ranging in length from 1.64 km to 3.5 km, three tunnels are aimed primarily at Seoul, a strategic KPA target.

6-148. All four tunnels remained undiscovered until they actually crossed the military demarcation line (MDL) into South Korea. The length of the tunnel passageways south of the MDL ranges from 435–1,100 m. The estimated number of troops able to pass through the tunnels ranges from 4,000 soldiers per hour for Tunnel #1 to 8,000 soldiers per hour for the other three tunnels. There are sources that estimate an even higher troop movement capacity. Some of the tunnels could also move heavy weapons, such as large machine guns or small-caliber artillery. One of the tunnels even possesses a concrete interior instead of a dirt floor. Tunnel #3 is unique, as the diggers installed a rail system to remove the debris created during its excavation and a mechanical system to take the water out of the tunnel on the North Korean side of the MDL.

6-149. Some analysts, as well as the South Korean Defense Ministry, estimate as many as 17 to 21 more KPA tunnels cross the MDL into South Korea. This estimate is supported by another North Korean defector, who stated during his debriefing in the early 1970s that Kim Il Sung ordered every forward-deployed KPAGF division along the DMZ to dig and maintain at least two infiltration tunnels into South Korea. If a general war were to resume between the two Koreas, it is likely that SOF could use the infiltration tunnels as one of their methods to gain access to South Korean rear areas. The SOF would establish a “second front” by creating chaos in the South Korean strategic rear areas through attacking military CPs and key logistical centers. Table 6-1 compares the specifications of the four infiltration tunnels discovered so far, and figure 6-19 shows their locations.

Table 6-1. Known North Korean infiltration tunnels

<i>Data Point</i>	<i>Tunnel #1</i>	<i>Tunnel #2</i>	<i>Tunnel #3</i>	<i>Tunnel #4</i>
Location	8 km NE of Korangpo	13 km N of Chorwan	4 km S of Panmunjon	26 km NE of Yanggu
Invasion route	Korangpo-Uijongbu-Seoul	Chorwan-Ponchon-Seoul	Munsan-Seoul	Sohwa-Wontong-Seoul
Troop capacity, per hour	4,000	8,000	8,000	8,000
Total length, km	3.5	3.5	1.64	2.05
Length south of the MDL, m	1,000	1,100	435	1,030
Distance from Seoul, km	65	101	44	203
Depth below surface, m	45	50–160	70–73	145
Tunnel height, m	1.2	2	1.95	1.6
Tunnel width, m	0.9	2	2.1	2.6
Tunnel lining	Concrete	None	None	None
Discovery date	15 NOV 1974	19 MAR 1975	17 OCT 1978	3 MAR 1990
km kilometers m meters MDL military demarcation line N north NE northeast S south				



Figure 6-19. Known North Korean infiltration tunnel locations

6-150. South Korean units and their allies continue to monitor suspected tunnel entrances in North Korea as well as possible exits south of the DMZ. In the past, the South Korean military built countertunnels to intercept the KPAGF tunnels and make them inoperable for use during an invasion. Countertunneling is a costly endeavor, however, and the exorbitant expense may cause South Korea to employ other countermeasures if another KPAGF underground invasion route is discovered.

6-151. The South Korean media regularly publish articles about North Korean tunneling activities. In October 2014, a retired South Korean general claimed North Korea has drilled at least 84 invasion tunnels into South Korea, with some of these tunnels being 64 km long and capable of reaching all the way to Seoul. In all likelihood, this information is erroneous, as the South Korean Defense Ministry believes no tunnel could extend beyond 10 km south of the DMZ due to groundwater issues in South Korea and the need to pass successfully beneath the Imjin River. The South Korean Defense Ministry, however, does believe there are undiscovered North Korean infiltration tunnels in existence.

6-152. In April 2015, Israel announced one of its leading defense electronics firms, Elbit Systems, recently developed a system that could locate underground tunnels with almost 100% accuracy. Due to the difference in the soil composition between the Gaza Strip and the Korean Peninsula, the equipment may not operate at the same level of success. Some South Koreans spend their free time searching for tunnels, but no new ones have been located in over a quarter century. Still, the South Korean Government and military continue to search for additional infiltration tunnels in the DMZ, which is off limits to civilian personnel, while the amateur detectives search in areas south of the DMZ.

This page intentionally left blank.